



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

SECOND MEETING, 2025

Tuesday, 1st July, 2025

The House met at 2.22 p.m.

[MR FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, there will be no Roll Call, no National Pledge, no Message from His Excellency the President and there is no Formal Communication.

Hon Members, let us look at item numbered 6, Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 27th June, 2025 is under correction. Page 1, 2—

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I just want to seek your guidance on your deferment of the National Pledge. I come under Order 69 and with your permission, I read:

“The House shall recite the National Pledge as set out in the Fourth Schedule at the First

Sitting of every week of a Meeting”

Mr Speaker, I am minded to, in this particular Order, indicate that I deem it a mandatory requirement of the House to recite the National Pledge at every Meeting. I am also guided by the pronouncement of the Speaker on this matter when he indicated that as a House, we should be guided by our own Standing Orders. So, Mr Speaker, I want to seek your guidance.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Did the Order say every day or every week? **Mr Boamah-Nyarko:** It says every week. It says that at “the First

Sitting”. My position is that it is the First Sitting of every week and today is our First Sitting of the week.

So, I think we should—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, you are right but we are masters of our own rules. So, we are not taking the National Pledge.

Hon Members, page 3...7

Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, on page 7, I would first deal with the item numbered 5 (i), “Staff and Pupils of Odokor...”. I am not quite sure, but I think that there should be an “r” after the second “o”. It can be checked. I am not sure, but let us cross check to get the right spelling of “Odorkor”

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Table Office, kindly check the correct spelling of “Odorko”

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, under the item numbered 40 on page 7, Nyarko, Kingsley (Prof) (Kwadaso) was marked absent. Mr Speaker, I duly applied being mindful of Orders 15 and 16, particularly the consequences of Order 16 and did the needful. I applied for leave of absence and this is a copy.

[The Hon Member showed his leave of absence letter]

I was also on the parliamentary delegation to La Côte d’Ivoire with the Majority Chief Whip and a couple of others. But sadly, myself, Mr Rockson Dafeamekpor and Mr Vincent Oppong Asamoah have been marked absent and I plead with you that our names be deleted and placed under—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Has the leave of absence been processed or you are holding the application for the leave of absence?

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am holding the application for leave of absence and the approval by the Hon Deputy Minority Whip.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, it means that it has not been processed and that is why. So, liaise with the Table Office to sort that out. Normally, when they give you the approval, you have to send it to the Table Office, and they will work on it and take note.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, but I am saying that we were on a parliamentary delegation, an official delegation from Parliament. So, why should we be marked absent? Firstly, the needful was done and granted that the leave of absence letter was not transmitted to the Second Deputy Speaker—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Kingsley Nyarko, sometimes the fault is from us. You know, the Whips only recommend the leave of absence, but it must be approved by the Speaker. So, what you are holding is not the approval of the Speaker, but the recommendation from the Whip. So, technically, the document that you are holding is not approval. You would agree with me. That is why I am advising that we do not belabor this point but liaise with the Clerks-at-the-Table and let the needful be done.

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I am guided, but—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompseh): Mr Speaker, you are right and I will work closely with Prof Nyarko to get the matter resolved. Mr Speaker, I have also suffered these concerns a couple of times and it is best dealt with when you liaise with the Table Office. So, let us go by the counsel of Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you Hon Minority Chief Whip. Page 8...10—

Hon Members, in the absence of any further correction, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Friday, 27th June, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, the *Official Report* of Friday, 20th June, 2025, under correction. Any correction?

Yes, Hon Member?

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Mr Speaker, I stand not to be very repetitive of our non-receipt of these documents that come before the House for consideration. We do not have it served either electronically or hard copy. So, I wonder the basis upon which we are going to do the review of these documents.

Mr Speaker, at my last submission, I indicated that these *Official Reports* should at least get to us in reasonable time, so that Members can peruse and make the needed correction, instead of running through it and getting it approved.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, Hon Member, you are right. I would want to stand it down.

2.32 p.m.

Yes, Majority Leader? We have an Urgent Question being the item numbered 7; however, the Minister for Health is also in the House to brief us on COVID-19.

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we can take the briefing from the

Minister. If we can vary the order of Business and go to Statements, so that the Minister can make a Statement on the situation of COVID-19 in the country, then we can come back to Urgent Questions, which is the item numbered 7.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, I am most grateful.

Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, you have to, at least, hear from us.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Dafeamekpor: — *rose* —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: No, I was going to say we support it. Mr Speaker, we called for the Minister to be here, and the Minister was here early enough. Except to say that there are other matters apart from the briefing. So he should liaise with Leadership and deal with these matters. Having said that, I support the application.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, you have the floor.

STATEMENT

COVID-19 Outbreak at the University of Ghana

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to update this House and through you, the people of Ghana, on the recent development at

the University of Ghana that has attracted national attention.

Mr Speaker, while COVID-19 is no longer regarded as a global health emergency, it has not disappeared. Like many other viruses, we anticipate it to flare up occasionally, especially during certain seasons. In recent weeks, our National Disease Surveillance System detected an increase in cases at the University of Ghana. These cases have been traced to a familiar variant, the Omicron subvariant, which we have managed before. It spreads easily, but fortunately, it usually causes mild illness.

Mr Speaker, the recent COVID-19 cases are localised at the University of Ghana community only. I am proud to inform this House that the cases were detected through Ghana's Influenza Surveillance System and confirmed by the Noguchi Memorial Institute for Medical Research. This national network of sentinel sites operates across all 16 regions. While many countries have scaled down or even stopped routine COVID-19 testing, Ghana has continued to integrate COVID-19 monitoring into its broader surveillance of respiratory viruses.

This foresight and commitment to preparedness allowed us to detect the current outbreak easily and respond swiftly. It is a clear demonstration of Ghana's leadership in maintaining vigilance even at the end of the global emergency phase. This should reassure all Ghanaians that should there be any case outside the University campus, our

surveillance system remains active and ready to detect and respond effectively.

Mr Speaker, as of now, out of 316 suspected cases, 107 of those cases have been confirmed as COVID-19. Fortunately, there are no hospitalisations and more importantly, no deaths. So far, the outbreak is limited to the University community. It has not spread widely to other parts of Accra or the rest of the country. As I mentioned earlier, all confirmed cases are recovering well.

Mr Speaker, after sending a team to investigate, we found a few key issues that fuelled the spread. The biggest factor was a recent hall celebration held in the University. These events brought large crowds together with little use of face masks or distancing. Following our investigations, even after the University community became aware, we also noticed a drop in adherence to basic COVID-19 safety protocols and some challenges with contact tracing.

Mr Speaker, when the first signals came in, we moved quickly. Here is what we did. We sent a national team to work with the University and municipal health authorities held meetings with the Director-General of Ghana Health Service, head of Noguchi and the School of Public Health. We issued alerts to all health facilities nationwide. The University suspended all hall week activities, launched a campus-wide education campaign using posters, campus radio and student leaders.

Mr Speaker, what next? We are not stopping there. Additional steps

underway include supporting the University of Ghana Hospital and the Student Clinic with more resources, preparing the Ghana Infectious Disease Centre to handle severe cases if any occur, holding face-to-face sessions with student bodies and faculty, providing more Personal Protective Equipment (PPEs) and training for frontline health workers, enhancing our data tracking in all health facilities, including mapping where cases are coming from, and continuing to test and monitor daily.

Mr Speaker, I want to assure Ghanaians that this is not a new virus and we are not back to 2020. This Omicron variant has been with us before. Yes, it spreads fast, but it is mostly mild and we know how to manage it. We have beaten back bigger waves before and we can do it again with calm cooperation and good public health practices.

Mr Speaker, I wish to clarify that COVID-19 vaccination is no longer part of the country's routine immunisation programme. Indeed, this is the case in most countries. That said, vaccinations remain one of the important tools that can be used to control the spread of COVID-19 infections and more importantly, prevent severe diseases and deaths. As a result, and in preparation for a potential surge, we have initiated the necessary processes to secure vaccination in-country. This is in line with our policy to protect the health of vulnerable populations, particularly people with underlying medical conditions and the aged, who are more likely to develop more severe diseases.

Additionally, I wish to assure the public that treatment is available for COVID-19. Paxlovid, an antiviral that is taken twice a day for five days only is recommended for patients with mild to moderate COVID-19, who have comorbidities such as diabetes and hypertension. It has proven effective and has minimal side effects. Generally, Mr Speaker, treatment for those who get infected is based on symptoms. Most people recover at home. For more serious cases, our hospitals are prepared and stocked to provide oxygen therapy and all the necessary care.

Mr Speaker, let me also mention that we are seeing a rise in seasonal flu cases, as we do have during the rainy season. These flu symptoms – fever, cough, sore throat – can look like COVID-19, so we urge anyone feeling unwell to go to the nearest health facility.

Also, though the number of cholera cases are down, we are still reporting cases, especially during this rainy season. Some of the risks factors for cholera lie beyond the health sector.

2.42 p.m.

We urge all to wash their hands with soap under running water, eat food that is hot and drink potable drinking water.

Mr Speaker, you would agree with me that the tackling of cholera goes beyond the health sector; keeping our environment clean is also a very important way of preventing cholera in our country.

Mr Speaker, finally, as of 29th June, we had confirmed 133 cases of Mpox, mostly in the Western, Greater Accra and Western North Regions. It is essential to note that there are currently no admissions and we have had no deaths associated with Mpox outbreak to date. Additionally, except for the cases confirmed in the past week, all affected individuals have fully recovered. Mpox spreads through close contact and we all need to stay safe. We should avoid close contact with anyone with symptoms suggestive of Mpox, which includes fever, rash, headache and swelling lymph nodes, and protect ourselves by washing our hands regularly with soap and water.

Specific to COVID-19, here is what each of us can do to help stop the spread. I must add that most of these universal precautions apply to both flu and COVID-19. We must wash hands regularly with soap and water, wear a mask in crowded or poorly ventilated places, stay home when feeling unwell, avoid gathering if we are sick and go to the nearest clinic as soon as we notice symptoms. The Ministry of Health has made sure that our responses are well-resourced. Personal Protective Equipment (PPEs), test kits and treatment supplies are all in place. Health workers are being supported and emergency centres like the Ghana Infectious Disease Centre are all on standby.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, this is a localised outbreak and we are on top of it. There is no need for panic. However, we must remain vigilant and responsible.

The Ministry of Health and its agencies remain committed to protecting the health of all Ghanaians, students, workers, families and the vulnerable alike. Let us each do our part to keep our communities safe.

Mr Speaker, COVID-19 is not over, but neither is our resolve. May the good Lord bless our homeland, Ghana. I thank you for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Minister.

Hon Members, before opening the floor for comments, permit me to acknowledge the presence of a revered delegation. Hon Members, I have the pleasure to introduce to you the Members of the Portfolio Committee on Higher and Tertiary Education, Innovation, Science and Technology Development from the Parliament of Zimbabwe who are here on a study visit.

The objective of this visit is to gain insights into Ghana's best practices in advancing innovation and technology in higher and tertiary education. The delegation will examine policies, frameworks and sustainable strategies supporting innovation hubs and industrial parks. Key interests include how academic research is aligned with industry needs and how sustainable funding models are applied.

Our visitors are: Hon Dr Thokozani Khupe, Chairperson, Leader of the Delegation; Hon Julianna Makuvire, Member of Parliament; Hon Pathisiwe Machangu, Member of Parliament; Hon

Kevin Mutimbanyoka, Member of Parliament; Hon Master Makope, Member of Parliament; Mr Pensel Marunga, Committee Clerk; Ms Panashe Paloma Chabwera, Research Officer; Mr Amon Nyahada, Trade Officer, Zimbabwe Embassy in Ghana.

Hon Members, on behalf of the House, I welcome the delegation to Parliament and I wish them fruitful deliberations. Once again you are welcome to Ghana.

[Delegation from the Parliament of Zimbabwe were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me also use the opportunity to acknowledge the presence of our revered students at the gallery.

First on my list is Corpus Christi Senior High School led by Elijah Osborn Quami, a teacher. They are from Tema West and are 32 in number.

[Students of Corpus Christi Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we have Istiqama Senior High School led by Luke Dabiena, master in charge of cadets. They are from Wenchi and are 54 in number.

[Students of Istiqama Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then we have Girls in Parliament led by Racheal Bempong Nyarkoah, Girls' Education officer. They are from Abuakwa North and are 71 in number.

[Delegation of Girls in Parliament were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Then Alogboshi, '1' Basic led by Mrs Eunice Die, headmistress. They are from Okaikwei North and are 55 in number.

[Pupils of Alogboshi '1' Basic School were acknowledged]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on behalf of the House, I welcome our students and wish them a fruitful visit to Parliament of Ghana.

Hon Members, now, comments.

Hon Kingsley Nyarko, you have the floor.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, I am grateful once again for indulging me to pass a brief comment on the Statement ably delivered by our Minister for Health.

Mr Speaker, it is sad that COVID-19 has resurfaced and I am happy that no lives have been lost. The current Government was in opposition when we were saying that there was the need to keep the COVID-19 Levy because COVID-19, according to the World Health Organisation, was still around. They said no. When they win power, they will remove the COVID-19 Levy. Now, reality has dawned on us and that the previous administration has been vindicated that the disease is still in existence— *[Interruption]*

Is the Minister now in the position to still keep it or remove it? [**Some Hon Members:** Remove it!] This is because we were saying that we needed that support to build our health infrastructure, to ensure that we build buffers and the capacity of our health institutions, so that we will be able to deal with this disease and other ones that will emerge in the future but they kick against it. My concern is that Ghanaians are waiting on him to decide how he is going to deal with this matter. Is he going to remove it or maintain it?

2.52 p.m.

Please, keep to your promise. Ghanaians did you the honours by voting for you because of that promise; we want to plead with you to keep it. On a more—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Prof Nyarko, I just want to remind you of Order 91(3).

Prof Nyarko: Mr Speaker, my major concern is interventions that the Ministry is putting in place to ensure that our children in our schools at all levels, especially those at the basic levels, are kept safe because it is not enough to say that we should be calm. Some Ghanaians and I are going through uneasy calm, so the Hon Minister should convince us on what the Ministry is putting in place to ensure that our children in that school are all kept hale, hearty and safe.

On that score, Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for indulging me once again.

Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (NDC — Lambussie): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by the Hon Minister for Health.

Mr Speaker, I want to begin by commending our indefatigable Minister for Health and the Ministry—*[Hear! Hear!]*—Today, I believe every Ghanaian is assured and reassured that we are safe and this Statement has calmed our nerves. The initial media reportage sparked a bit of fear and panic; that is expected because of the devastating effect that COVID-19 had. So, whenever the name of COVID-19 is mentioned, people get worried. But our assurance, today, is coming from the fact that the Hon Minister has given us a comprehensive report that says that, even though 316 suspected cases were reported and about 117 confirmed, there is no hospitalisation.

Secondly, the Hon Minister is making us aware that the health system is on top of the case. They are in total control. They know the specific variant that is causing this outbreak. The outbreak is below epidemic proportion; it has nothing for us to be worried about. It is no reason for anybody to be calling for maintenance or otherwise of a COVID-19 levy. Rather, it gives us hope and confidence that there is no cause for alarm.

The Hon Minister went beyond just COVID-19 to also tell us the status of Mpox in the country. I think it is also reassuring that we do not have active cases and there is no hospitalisation. I

think the take-home word for every Ghanaian watching us today or following this proceeding is that our surveillance system is robust and that should give all of us confidence that not only COVID-19 but should any other infectious disease get into this country, by whatever means, it will be picked up. This situation has been detected and it is fully under control. That should give us confidence and I think that we are very grateful to the Hon Minister for responding promptly and for containing the situation at the University of Ghana to keep the rest of the country in peace, calmness and perfect health. We are grateful.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): Thank you, Mr. Speaker, for the opportunity and I thank the Hon Minister for Health for the response and update on COVID-19. While our Hon Member was just talking, he appreciated the fact that COVID-19 has not led to any death or hospitalisation.

I would like to know from the Hon Minister for Health some of the lessons learnt from the previous way we managed COVID-19, so that we, as a country, will be able to look forward to properly putting strategies in place for any outbreak that may come. Because over the past three years that COVID-19 came up, there were some strategies that were put in place and I would like the Hon Minister to give us some updates and some of the lessons that have been

learnt. I also want to encourage the Hon Minister that, as a country, we should integrate COVID-19 monitoring, as well as influenza surveillance, to inform medical research in the future because such outbreaks can be coming up.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Mr Speaker, I thank you so much. Like my Hon Colleague, Prof Beyuo, I also wish to use this opportunity to thank the Hon Minister for his swiftness and promptness in respect of the response to the current outbreak of COVID-19.

Mr Speaker, it is good to note that we have, today, a Hon Minister who is so agile, very effective and efficient and has moved in swiftly to partner the university community to contain this particular variant. I am glad to know that, once upon a time, while on campus, we all had very joyous moments during hall weeks. A moment like this, we did all kinds of things by intermingling with one another. Rightly as the Hon Minister has observed, it is possible to be a fertile breeding ground for this particular variant.

Mr Speaker, I recall vividly, during the outbreak of COVID-19 under the previous New Patriotic Party (NPP) Government, that there was a famous mantra that we can always bring back the economy; what we cannot do is to bring back lives. Mr Speaker, the economy was never brought back to life— [*Laughter*—Mr Speaker, fortunately, today—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, be guided by Order 91(3).

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, I am guided. Mr Speaker, fortunately, today, the economy is robust. It is very strong, so, without COVID-19 Levy, we can survive. It is being done. The Hon Minister is actively working. The President is in full flight to handle every sector of this economy, including the health sector.

Mr Speaker, I would only wish to urge the Hon Minister, while concluding, that University of Ghana, particularly the student class, is very active. They might not, after all, have underlying causes, so we cannot use it as a case study to conclude that this particular variant cannot deal us a huge blow. So, we must take every legitimate action to safeguard those within the age brackets or those who are quite old, so we may not go back to the kind of fatalities we experienced during the first outbreak.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

3.02 p.m.

Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale): Mr Speaker, I would like to join my Colleagues to thank the Minister for Health for coming to this particular House to update us on a very serious matter.

Mr Speaker, we all recall, not with relish, that COVID-19 ravaged the Ghanaian economy. Not just the Ghanaian economy, but economies of the

world. The impact of COVID-19 is well established that even while the opposition failed to recognise that within or outside the shores of the country, they acknowledge that COVID-19 dealt a blow on the Ghanaian economy.

Mr Speaker, we do not want, wish, or pray that we get to a situation where this situation will rear its ugly heads on the shores of the Ghanaian economy. If we do not take care, COVID-19—And I am not trying to be a scaremonger or raise any alarm, but I am happy that the Minister for Health has now found solace in new expressions like, let us stay calm; this too shall pass. I am happy that he has now found those words worthy of usage because when the former President used those particular words, he was the lead person, as the Ranking Member, who said the President was not doing anything and that he was only giving hope. I am happy that he is now in the dispatch box trying to give us hope that this thing will not ravage our economy,

Mr Speaker, people think they are not vulnerable at the place that COVID-19 has resurfaced, the University of Ghana campus; they are the most vulnerable. These are students, for crying out loud. If the health of those particular students are affected, they cannot learn. We need to do everything within our ability to contain it.

Mr Speaker, someone mentioned that we can live without the COVID-19 levy. Why are we keeping it after we had promised to take away the levy? If we can do without the COVID-19 levy, the Minister for Finance and his Deputy are

here, let us bring the Motion so that we scrap it under a certificate of urgency, because from their own words, we do not need that levy. So, we are happy, willing and committed to support the Minister to ensure that there is calm, that we do not scare the Ghanaian people and we do not cause any panic and fear, but we believe that this too shall pass.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah? Did I get the name correct?

Prof Ayensu-Danquah: Yes, please.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: You have the floor.

Prof Grace Ayensu-Danquah (NDC — Essikadu-Ketan): Mr Speaker, thank you for allowing me to make a comment on the Statement of the Hon Minister. I would also like to take this opportunity to actually commend the Minister. I think what he has assured the public is good; the public is reassured. He has told us that there is only 316 suspected cases and 117 of them have been confirmed. There has been no hospitalisation and no death.

Mr Speaker, the Minister has given us all the series of things he is doing to combat this new resurgence of COVID-19 and he has also told us that it is a milder form. In terms of vulnerability that my Hon Member on the other Side mentioned, when we talk about the students in terms of vulnerability, they are at low risk because the virus usually affects people that have comorbidities. When we talk about comorbidities, we mean people who have other underlying

diseases like hypertension and diabetes. So, when it comes to any form of virus or especially, the flu-like viruses, those are the people that it affects the most.

So, the students, as long as we have done all the proper surveillance and contact tracing—The Minister has made sure that their contacts have been traced and they are following up aggressively on the students, I truly believe that they are safe, as the Minister mentioned. We will continue to reassure the country and as the Minister said, he is on top of it; he has this under control. The only thing I will add is that we have to do public education, in terms of educating the public to go back to social distancing and especially, proper hand-washing. Those who have respiratory diseases must stay away from other family members and when they are going out, they must ensure that they have face masks. I think that would be the bigger thing to reassure the country.

Again, on this note, Mr Speaker, I would like to really commend the Hon Minister for Health for such a wonderful job and I would call him, “the rapid response Minister”. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip, you have the floor.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, let me join Colleagues to also thank the Minister for making time to be with us and this is what we want.

When the Business Statement was presented, we made the call that

following the signals—Mr Speaker, you will bear witness that the Minister for Health should be here. This is just the beginning. Next, the Governor of the Bank of Ghana (BoG) and the Executive Secretary of the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC) must be here. This is governance—*[Interruption]*—I am not veering off. I will speak to the issues.

Mr Speaker, I think I want to thank my Friend, the Minister. In fact, he was early in the Chamber and when he saw me, he related that he was here to deal with the concern. This is a matter that should not be taken lightly. I see people are making their own deductions and statements, but we should not take this thing lightly. We can all appreciate the devastating effect of COVID-19 and the fact that we have not recorded fatality does not mean we should go to sleep.

Mr Speaker, I am happy the Minister ran us through the statistics. Over 300 suspected cases and over 100 confirmed cases. The confirmation of 100 cases cannot be a light matter, especially when it has to do with COVID-19. It is a grave matter. I am a bit worried about some few observations. Mr Speaker, the Minister should correct me if I am wrong, but I am aware the University of Ghana issued a statement and I thought that, as grave as this matter is, that statement should rather have been issued by the Ghana Health Service (GHS). That is what comes to me. It should have been issued by the GHS and that will confirm that, indeed, our surveillance and monitoring systems are up.

For the University of Ghana to issue a statement, well, they have their independence, but all health directorates or any health sub-body should be working under the Ghana Health Service. So, there is a bit of disconnect there and I want the Minister to advert his mind to a thing like this. I see the Minister came with a full house. The professionals are all here; they should also take this in good stride. We are not criticising them, but these matters are important. Public health is a matter that we cannot take for granted.

Mr Speaker, besides the statistics the Minister has given, he also mentioned that support will be given to the University. I heard him say that. What kind of support? What are the details of it? Is it funding or equipment? The Minister may have to apprise this House. These are the representatives of the people and he needs to go into specifics and details. If he needs more money, this House has the mandate. We will give him more money, with the blessing of the Speaker, so that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Chief Whip, do not draw me into the debate—*[Laughter]*

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I will not invite you to do what you do not want to do, but Mr Speaker is also very scared of COVID-19. That I know. I know the Speaker does not want COVID-19 near this House or any of his family.

Mr Speaker, speaking to the matters, there should have also been a spirited public education. Mr Kwabena Mintah

Akandoh, I have not seen that spirited public education. We have not done that.

3.12 p.m.

Mr Speaker, he sat in one of the seats here when he was the Ranking Member for the Committee on Health. Like by now, he would be in his elements and the media all over the world; BBC, CNN, and everyone will hear of him. This is a grave matter and the Minister — I am happy he has given the statistics, but it is too subtle. We should go down a bit and put out some spirited public education. Because the Minister and I know that we should make hay while the sun shines. And it is important we track this matter down in its lane before it gets out of hand. I pray it does not get out of hand to the extent of what the previous administration experienced. That would be too bad for this country and the economy.

Now that we have the mandate and we have a bit of control, let us do more in terms of public education. Again, this briefing should be sustained. I want to suggest that every two weeks, the Minister —*[Interruption]*— he would not listen and he is there concluding. Is he the Minister? Or does he want to be the Minister's deputy? This reminds me, the Minister has no deputy. His Excellency the President should be reminded that there are four outstanding deputies. Hon Akandoh has no deputy. His hair is getting grey. The man is suffering. One moment, he is at Bolga; the other moment, he is here. The Minister for Health needs a deputy. It will help him.

So, Mr Speaker, I implore your consequential directives; two consequential directives. Firstly, with the threat of COVID-19, more funding should be given to Hon Akandoh. He needs more funds. Then, secondly, every two weeks, he should be meeting our Committee on Health and briefing them. I am not saying he should come to the Chamber, but he should carry the Committee on Health along then the chairperson can come and brief the Plenary. This is important. This is the first time he has come since the matter broke.

We have heard his reassuring words that we should not panic. Yes, but it does not lie in his mouth to tell us not to panic. It is the reality on the ground that will tell us whether we will panic or not. We have over 100 confirmed cases and he says we should not panic. We have over 100 cases—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order!

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, they can say that we had thousands. They are not listening. Would they listen to me? Yes, we had thousands, so they should have a hindsight benefit. They should learn from what we went through and not say that we had thousands and they just have 100. So what? So we should go and sleep? No. We have 100 confirmed cases at Legon alone.

Mr Speaker, look at that. We can do the extrapolation. I am happy that the Majority Leader is here. I have not said that he has had COVID-19, no. I have not

said that. Oftentimes, when the Majority Leader presents the Business of the House and we say that Ministers must come to this House, the Majority Leader will do his own thing and say we should file Questions. This one was our instance. I do not know if he would have come if we had not made the call. He would not have come. And now his hair is getting grey. The Minister's hair is getting grey.

The Akandoh that I know, Mr Speaker, when I was a youth organiser, he was a youth organiser in the Western Region. He did not have grey hair. He is suffering. He needs a deputy. So, having said this, I want to commend my good Friend for coming. But to caution that it cannot be a one-off. We must get the Committee on Health involved in this whole action to track down COVID-19 and the Minister should regularly carry the Committee along so that at least Parliament will be apprised.

So, in the absence of he coming to the Plenary to give us a briefing, at least the Committee of Parliament would have been carried along. Mr Speaker, I pray your outfit to give this consequential directive. And particularly, our own; the Exchequer, Minister for Finance, his is an emergency case, COVID-19. Look at the Hon Minister's face. Hon Akandoh needs more funding, so that he will come atop the situation and be able to track down this deadly ailment.

Mr Speaker, having said this, I want to thank you for the space and also thank the Majority Leader who heeded our call. But we are not done yet. This is a work

in progress. The Bank of Ghana Governor must come. And then the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission's (PURC) Executive Secretary must also come to the Committee of the Whole and brief us properly. Thank you for indulging me. I am grateful.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

First Deputy Majority Whip (Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. I would like to take the opportunity to thank the Minister for the quick response.

Mr Speaker, COVID-19 has never left Ghana and has never left the whole world. It is at the corner. It is like when we had the first cholera outbreak, the whole world supported but it never vanished. And when it is time for it to come, it will come again.

Mr Speaker, the truth of the matter is that when we got the first malaria outbreak, even though the World Health Organisation (WHO) came to support, we still have malaria in the system. Which means we have to protect ourselves from mosquitoes. So once COVID-19 is around — when the weather is cold, we need to respect the protocols and make sure that we protect ourselves. That is the fact.

We should not behave as if it is gone and we will not see it again. Whatever the case, it is around. So let us still respect the protocols. When we are in public, we should have our hand

sanitisers, wash our hands, and protect and educate our children. We should not leave our children to go and come and then blame the Minister for the outbreak.

Mr Speaker, when the weather is hot, we still experience some cold. And when the weather is cold, we should expect COVID-19 too. So let us all work together as Ghanaians and ensure that we protect ourselves from it. Let our hand sanitisers be with us. We should be mindful of shaking hands. When in public, we should do whatever it is to ensure that we protect ourselves. We thank God we have a Minister who is very dynamic and vibrant and responds to cases quickly. Because just last week they complained and he is here. We can see this is a Government that is ready to solve problems. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, any concluding remarks?

Mr Akandoh: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, just to assure you that I did not appear on the floor of the House just to come and read a report to the House. Just today, I paid a working visit to the University of Ghana campus. I engaged the management of the university; I went to the health facilities on the campus and observed that the situation is very calm.

Mr Speaker, the University of Ghana has a population of over 65,000, and if we calculate in terms of percentage, the confirmed cases or even the suspected

cases are less than 0.2 per cent of the total population. It is about 0.15 per cent.

3.22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I have already told this House and with your permission, I will read how we detected this spike and that should give everybody the assurance that the Ministry is on top of the issues. To allay your fear, the Omicron variant is not any new virus. We have dealt with it before and it has treatment.

Mr Speaker, the issue of how will our school children be going to school and all that, for your information, it is a localised issue. It has not even gone beyond the borders of the university. [*Uproar*]

Mr Speaker, the surveillance indicates clearly that even the adjoining constituencies have not detected cases and we are keeping our eyes closed on the situation and will update the country as and when it is possible.

Mr Speaker, please permit me to read and I quoted in the Statement that;

“I am proud to inform this House that the cases were detected through Ghana's influenza surveillance System and confirmed by the Noguchi Memorial Institute for Medical Research. This national network of centennial sites operates across all the 16 regions.

Mr Speaker, I can assure the House that we are closely monitoring the development and as and when necessary—The Minority Chief Whip wanted to know the kind of support we

are giving to the University. We are determined to give the University whatever it takes to contain the virus without spilling out and today, when I visited the campus, I sent Personal Protective Equipments (PPEs), I sent hand sanitisers and some of the requests they made that we did not have, I have instructed the Ministry to procure them to make sure that we contain the virus within the confines of the University. So be rest assured.

Mr Speaker, I thank you, for the opportunity.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on behalf of the House, I thank the Minister for coming to brief the House about this very important issue. I intend not to make any consequential directives but urge upon the Minister to take it as an advice and work appropriately to combat the situation.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, we thank the Minister for attending upon the House to give us this briefing. I know that some Friends on the other Side have whispered to me that even though the problem is a localised matter on the campus of University of Ghana, because of some relationships that they have on those campuses, —[*Laughter*]—they fear that the matter will be exported to their homes. They should manage those relationships well; if Hon Members manage the relationships well, they will not create problems at home.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, we have an Urgent Question standing in the name of the Minister. While the Minister is here, do we take that Urgent Question?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think with your leave, if we can have the Agreement itemised as 10(b) laid, then we can go to Question time so that you can refer it to the Committee to be working on it whilst we are taking Questions. So, with your indulgence, Mr Speaker, if we can vary the order of Business and take 10(b)?

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well, Minority Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we certainly have no option but on a more serious note, we know those on the other Side who visit Legon at night. We know them, especially the Chief Whip, we know them—[*Laughter*]—

Mr Speaker, having said that, I have no objection.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have the Minority Chief Whip and Majority Chief Whip. I have heard Chief Whip, so this will not cause any problem. It could either be Minority or Majority. So, let us leave it like that. Hon Members, accordingly, let us vary the order of Business to take the item numbered 10(b), At the Commencement of Public Business.

Yes, Minister for Finance.

Mr Ayariga —*rose*—

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Finance is out of the jurisdiction. He is not even in the country. So, Mr Speaker, I crave your indulgence and ask our counterparts on the other Side to allow his Deputy Minister stand in for him and then lay the Agreement.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Chief Whip?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I am aware the Minister for Finance travelled together with the Minister for Roads and Highways but they are back into the country—*[Interruption]*—They are not back?

Yes, but, Mr Speaker, why such a grave matter? Mr Speaker, it is International Development Association (IDA), US\$360 million. This is huge. All right, it is just the laying, we will not object—*[Laughter]*—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Finance Minister, you may now lay the item numbered 10(b).

PAPERS

By the Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Ampem-Nyarko) on behalf of the Minister—

Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance)

and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing.

Referred to the Finance Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Yes, we can go back to Questions, the item numbered 8.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do we jump from item 7 to 8? There is an Urgent Question standing in the name of the Minister.

Hon Members, the Minister is here, the item numbered 7, Urgent Questions, standing in the name of Mumuni Muhammad Nurideen, Member of Parliament for Nalerigu/Gambaga.

URGENT QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF HEALTH

State of Disease Infection Centre in Nalerigu

Alhaji Mumuni Muhammed Nurideen (NPP —Nalerigu/Gambaga): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Health the status of the Disease Infection Centre in Nalerigu, started by the previous Government.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister?

3.32 p.m.

Minister for Health (Mr Kwabena Mintah Akandoh) (MP): Mr Speaker, I wish to thank the Hon Member for this Question regarding the status of the Nalerigu Infectious Disease Centre. Mr Speaker, the Centre in Nalerigu was initiated as part of the Government's strategic agenda to strengthen the national response to the COVID-19 pandemic. While the majority of COVID-19-related health infrastructure was funded through World Bank, the facilities at Nalerigu, Sunyani and Takoradi were financed through direct Government of Ghana budgetary allocations. Mr Speaker, following the award of the initial contract, the contractor regrettably failed to perform in accordance with the agreed terms and timelines. This necessitated the termination of the contract.

At the time of termination, Mr Speaker, the project was only at a substructure level. In line with the provisions of the Public Procurement Act, the Ministry engaged the Public Procurement Authority and obtained the approval to proceed with the restricted tendering processes for the selection of a new contractor to continue the project.

However, Mr Speaker, despite the approval granted by the Public Procurement Authority, the procurement process could not be completed before the approval expired in February, 2025. This delay was due to two fundamental reasons:

One, post-termination technical due diligence had to be undertaken. This included a comprehensive reassessment of the works executed by the terminated contractor, realignment of the project scope, and the necessary redesign adjustment to meet updated technical, safety, and functional requirements. These processes required coordination with the Ghana Health Service and the project's technical consultant and took time to complete.

Two, in accordance with clause 15.2.6 of the conditions of the contract, the Ministry was required to address several close out obligations with the terminated contractor. These included securing the site, recovering all contractor's documents, assessing the value of partially completed works as provided under clause 15.3 and resolving issues related to the handover of any goods and subcontracted works. These close out processes were necessary to protect the interests of the employer and ensure proper documentation before engaging a new contractor.

Mr Speaker, I wish to assure this House that the Ministry has taken concrete steps to ensure the continuation of the project by including it in the 2025 Capital Investment Budget. As part of the continuation efforts, the Ministry is in the process of formally submitting a request to the Ministry of Finance for the issuance of a commencement certificate. This certificate will enable the Ministry to activate the procurement process and complete the project through a newly procured contractor.

Mr Speaker, we remain fully committed to the successful completion of the Nalerigu Infectious Disease Centre and we will take all the necessary administrative and financial steps to ensure that the project is completed and operationalised to serve the health needs of the people of Nalerigu and the surrounding regions.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary question?

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I want to find out from the Minister how soon the people of Nalerigu should expect the Ministry to re-award the project to a new contractor?

Mr Akandoh: Mr Speaker, as soon as possible.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further supplementary question?

Alhaji N. M. Mumuni: Mr Speaker, I expect soon to be very soon, so that the project could be completed very soon.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Hon Members, this being a constituency-specific Question, may we move to the item numbered 8?

Hon Minister, we thank you very much for coming to brief the House and answer Questions.

The item numbered 8, Questions. We will take Question 226, standing in the name of Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta, the Member of Parliament for Fanteakwa South. Hon Member, you have the floor.

ORAL ANSWERS TO QUESTIONS

MINISTRY OF FISHERIES AND AQUACULTURE DEVELOPMENT

Why Artisanal Fisheries Are Not Subject to the Closed Season

Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP—

Fanteakwa South): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development why artisanal fisheries are not subject to the closed season for the benefit of spawning and increase in fish stock.

Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development (Mrs Emelia Arthur) (MP): Mr Speaker, the marine artisanal fisheries play a crucial role in the livelihoods of rural coastal communities and contribute to nutrition (60 per cent of the country's protein requirement) and food security as well as to the local economy. The annual closed season for the marine fishing fleet was instituted as one of the fisheries conservation management strategies. A management measure should have multiple objectives — conservation, social and economic. The marine

artisanal canoe fleet was exempted from observing the closed season in 2025, in accordance with the current Government policy direction that aims to balance the multiple objectives and the needs of rural fishing communities with the sustainability of fish stocks. It is worth noting that the exemption does not negate the responsibility of fishers to comply with other traditional and statutory management measures. Marine artisanal fishers are required to observe traditional fishing practices such as fishing holidays on Tuesdays or any other day and comply with rules against illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing, under the supervision of Regional Fisheries Offices of the Fisheries Commission (FC), Landing Beach Enforcement Committees (LaBECs) and the respective Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Assemblies (MMDAs). The Fisheries Enforcement Unit (FEU) will also play their role in monitoring and enforcement. These measures remain consistent with Ghana's long-standing fisheries management strategy aimed at replenishing fish stocks and ensuring the sustainability of the sector.

We wish to indicate that the Government is exploring alternative conservation strategies that will holistically address emerging challenges confronting the sector including, the establishment of Ghana's first marine protected areas in the Greater Cape Three Points Area of the Ahanta West Municipality in the Western Region to encourage spawning, protect marine biodiversity and support resilience to climate change, strengthen co-

management structures, enforce gear restrictions and intensify monitoring and surveillance against IUU fishing.

Similarly, the Government is strategically pursuing the integration of science and indigenous knowledge and traditional practices to promote sustainability, culturally appropriate management strategies and community ownership and fisheries governance policy.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, any supplementary question?

Mr Ofori-Atta: Mr Speaker, I do not have a supplementary question, but I have a suggestion.

Mr Speaker, I am happy to learn of this new initiative in the aquaculture development because I see it as doing three things: increase in stock, compliance with new protocols and employ the local know-how, local experience and scientific trends. Mr Speaker, this is a business opportunity. I would suggest that—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, once you do not have a supplementary question, the rules do not allow you to address the House.

Mr Ofori-Atta: Mr Speaker, with your permission, I may—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: I owe a fidelity to the Rules.

Mr Ofori-Atta: Yes, please. I implore—

Mr First Deputy Speaker: So, with all due respect—The floor is now open for any other supplementary questions.

Yes, Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

3.42 p.m.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko: Mr Speaker, thank you for the liberty to ask a supplementary question. From the second paragraph, if you would indulge me, I will read a few lines:

“We wish to indicate that the Government is exploring alternative conservation strategies that will holistically address emerging challenges confronting the sector including...”

Mr Speaker, these words are comforting; at least, we are being told that plans are afoot for this to be done. However, I would like to know from the Minister when we would see the actual commencement and also the time frame within which these good ideas would be consummated.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, it is a process and a lot of research has already been done. I spent the whole of last week in each of the 22 fishing communities in the Ahanta West Municipality, engaging them about the need to set up the marine protected area. So, we have to go through the process, take a Cabinet memorandum to Cabinet, and *gazette it*. We have about

a month to declare the first marine protected area in Ghana.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the Question numbered 228, standing in the name of Mr Seth Osei-Akoto.

Immediate Measures to Sanitise Ghana's Fishing Sector

Mr Seth Osei-Akoto (NPP — Atwima Mponua): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development the immediate measures the Ministry is implementing to sanitise Ghana's fishing sector in light of the European Union's warning that Ghana faces a potential red card.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, in 2021, Ghana was issued a yellow card by the European Union after being identified as a non-compliant third country in the fight against illegal fishing activities. The Government, through the Ministry, has been engaging the European Union through the Ghana-European Union Dialogue to address concerns raised through an action plan, periodic update reports and validation exercises. We are happy to report that Ghana has made significant progress in resolving issues of concerns primarily related to lapses in regulatory framework, fisheries enforcement and traceability.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to report that, following my assumption of office, I have had the opportunity to engage His Excellency, the Ambassador of the EU Delegation to Ghana, as well as the

Director-General of the European Union Commission's Directorate-General for Maritime Affairs and Fisheries (DG-MARE) and have reiterated the commitment of the Government to carry on with the pending actions towards the reversal of the ban. A review of pending actions indicates that the enactment of the Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, with accompanying regulations, remains critical to enhance fisheries governance.

The Ministry has submitted the Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, 2025 to this august House and this has been referred to the Parliamentary Select Committee on Agriculture, Food and Cocoa Affairs for their necessary attention. I am certain that, this week or next week, the Report of the Committee will be taken in this House. I, therefore, appeal to my Colleagues, Hon Members, to prioritise the review and passage of the Bill when presented since it is a critical requirement for the lifting of the yellow card.

Mr Speaker, the Government has not reneged on its efforts to strengthen and combat illegal activities. It is recalled that the Ministry, in April 2025, suspended the licences of four trawl vessels engaged in transshipment and other illegalities at sea, sending a clear message to operators on the unwavering commitment of the Government to combat illegal fishing practices.

Thank you for the opportunity to submit a response on behalf of the Ministry.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member, any supplementary questions?

Mr Osei-Akoto: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, may I know from the Hon Minister, besides the enactment of the pending Fisheries and Aquaculture Bill, whether there are some actions to reverse the ban.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, he wants to know whether there are actions or steps being taken to reverse the ban.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, the final decision for the ban to be repealed lies with the EU. We have done everything they have said we should do. The last bit that is left is the law and the law is taking into consideration global trends, international laws, how to take care of our own fishers here in the country and also ensuring that illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing goes down. We here have taken all necessary steps, including the suspension of four licences and what is left is for this House to pass the Bill into law and we believe that will be it and the ban will be lifted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Osei-Akoto: Mr Speaker, I am done.

Mr Ofori-Atta: Mr Speaker, please, I have a second Question for the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Do you have a supplementary question?

Mr Ofori-Atta: No, a second Question; that is the Question numbered 227.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I skipped the Question numbered 227. So, you have the floor.

**Provision of Support to Promote
Inland Aquaculture for Misplaced
Food Crop Farmers in Fanteakwa
South**

Mr Duke William Allen Kwame Amoako-Atta Ofori-Atta (NPP — Fanteakwa South): Mr Speaker, I beg to ask the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development what support has provided to promote inland aquaculture as an alternative livelihood for displaced food crop farmers in the Fanteakwa South Constituency.

Mrs Arthur: Mr Speaker, as is the case, Ghana fisheries has three main sub-sectors: marine, inland and aquaculture. Ghana, as a nation, has paid more attention to marine than inland and aquaculture. It is our desire to focus more on inland and aquaculture going forward.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry plans to implement a new aquaculture initiative aimed at providing institutions and groups with targeted support to venture into aquaculture as a business. The situation in the Fanteakwa South Constituency where food crop farmers have been displaced has just come to my attention through this Question.

Mr Speaker, at this point, they may, please, put in a request for support and

we would go through the normal processes to provide support, as other Members of Parliament (MPs) have done the same. It is noted that, in 2024, 64 youth and women from Fanteakwa South benefited from the Aquaculture for Food and Jobs programme (AFJ), receiving 300 bags of fish feed and 50 tarpaulin tanks.

I hope those businesses went on well and we are willing to come and support further.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Any further questions?

Mr Ofori-Atta: Mr Speaker, there is no supplementary questions.

3.52 p.m.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, on the behalf of the House, I thank the Minister for attending upon the House and answering Questions scheduled for her. Hon Minister, you are discharged.

Hon Members, we come to the item numbered 10(a)(i).

Yes, Majority Leader?

PAPERS

By the Majority Leader —

Report of Leadership on the composition of the membership of the Pan-African Parliament.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 10(a)(ii).

By the Majority Leader —

Report of the Auditor-General on the Public Accounts of Ghana: Public Boards, Corporations and other Statutory Institutions for the Period Ended 31st December, 2024.

Referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 10(a)(iii).

By the Majority Leader —

Report of the Auditor-General on the Accounts of District Assemblies for the Financial Year ended 31st December 2024.

Referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 10(a)(iv).

By the Majority Leader —

Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Availability of Fertilisers to Small Holder Farmers in Ghana.

Referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 10(a)(v).

By the Majority Leader —

Performance Audit Report of the Auditor-General on the Provision and Maintenance of Toilet Facilities in Public Schools.

Referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the item numbered 10(a)(vi).

By the Majority Leader —

Report of the Auditor-General on the Management and Utilisation of the District Assemblies' Common Fund (DACF) and Other Statutory Funds for the year ended 31st December, 2024.

Mr Ayariga — rose —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, just for your direction. You know there are two types of reports. Here, I see Performance Audits and Accounting Audits. Now, when it is the accounts, that is how the money was spent, I think that would be the Public Accounts Committee, but if it is the actual performance where the toilet is built, how the toilet is performing, *et cetera*, I want to believe that the sector Committee might be the proper — So, if it is about schools, Committee on Education might be the best to look at that report, enquire into it and report back to us and not the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah: Mr Speaker, this is not the first time such reports have been referred to the Public Accounts Committee. So, it is embedded in, I think, Article 187 of the Constitution that such reports are referred to the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, I agree with you. The report of the Auditor-General is mostly added to the work of the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think it is high time we reconsidered how we do these things. It would be good that when it has to do with a particular sector, the Committee works with the Public Accounts Committee. I think it is better because the Committee is the one that really approved the budget of the sector, knows that a certain number of toilets are supposed to be built, where they are supposed to be built, the principle guiding the siting, *et cetera*. So, when the report comes, in terms of performance of that task, and that Committee is not the one reviewing it to ascertain whether it is done in accordance with the approval they made, but then it goes to the Auditor-General simply because he audited it, I think that the effectiveness of it —

So, even if in the past, we have always given all those things to the Public Accounts Committee, I think we should begin to vary it to include the leadership of the sector Committees.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I do not disagree with the Majority Leader, but I want him to look

at it from this angle as well. We know the Committee has oversight of the work of the Ministry and their job is to look at the resources that government has given through Parliament and in fact, Parliament is the one that gives to the Ministry to look at. So, they play the oversight role.

Once we allow the Auditor-General to do the audit and finish his work, he literally reports to Parliament. I will not say the Auditor-General is an officer of Parliament, but he reports to Parliament. So once he brings his report, it should be a different Committee that should really look at it to see whether the resources that were given, the infractions that were there and whether what the Auditor-General has raised is correct. I do not know how we want to get the Committee that played the oversight role to go back and look at it again. I want the Majority Leader to look at this from that angle as well.

For this one, they are purely looking at the report of the Auditor-General. It is not more about the resources that were given or how it was used even though that was raised by the Auditor-General. So, they are not looking at things outside what the Auditor-General has raised. It is purely what the Auditor-General has raised that they will look at.

So, if we get the Committee itself to go back and sit on it, there will be a lot of conflict of interest. I think that the Committee should be empowered to do enough oversight within the period before the Auditor-General does his work. If we allow them to join the Public Accounts Committee, we may be

defeating what Parliament is supposed to stand for. I stand to be corrected, but I just wanted him to look at it from this angle as well.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me support my Leader in this matter. Article 187(2), as referenced by my Brother, Mr Patrick Yaw Boamah, Mr Speaker, with your leave, it reads:

The public accounts of Ghana and of all public offices, including the courts, the central and local government administrations, of the Universities and public institutions of like nature, of any public corporation or other body or organisation established by an Act of Parliament shall be audited and reported on by the Auditor-General.

Mr Speaker, the matter raised by my Leader is to the effect that, in respect of the other reports regarding the accounts, the Public Accounts Committee, which I have been a long-serving Member of, is mandated to look at it. Mr Speaker, if you recall, Hon Kwabena Donkor used to fight this matter on the Floor. So, the Performance Audit Reports do not go to the Public Accounts Committee; they go to the substantive sector Committees, so he has always fought this matter. So, I agree that it is time we streamlined this.

The Performance Audit is in respect of projects done, whether the funds have been allocated.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: How different is it from a Performance Report of the institution? We have the Performance Report and the Performance Audit.

4.02 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, Mr Speaker, the Constitution is very clear. This is because in Article 187(2), it speaks of the accounts. The accounts are about utilisation of funds, but this one is about the utilisation of projects, whether projects that have been initiated or have been completed.

Yes, I agree that projects strictly may also be classified but the Constitution is very clear that the public accounts is about utilisation of funds, budget allocation, but the performance audit is about projects. That is why, for instance, the Public Interest and Accountability Committee (PIAC) has a separate report. What they do is that there is a team that goes round to see the funds that come from the Energy Sector Levy Act (ESLA) accounts on the petroleum utilisation, projects that Parliament has been told has been undertaken— They go and audit the projects and see whether the project commenced, completed, their level of completion and all that.

I support his position that we need to refer these ones to the sector Committees but the Auditor-General's Report on the Accounts falls squarely in the domain of the Public Accounts Committee.

Mr Speaker, Hon Kwabena Donkor if I may rehash always fought this and the

Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee is here.

Thank you very much.

Mrs Osei-Asare — *rose* —

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let me hear from the Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee.

Mrs Abena Osei Asare: Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Mr Speaker, the Constitution is very clear on reports that emanate from the Auditor-General and the Committee that is supposed to work on it. I do not think this is something we should belabour. When you look at the Standing Orders, Order 229 — duties of the Public Accounts Committee and let me start from (3). With your permission, please let me read:

“Pursuant to Article 187 (2) and (5) of the Constitution, the Public Accounts Committee shall examine the report of the Auditor-General on the public accounts of Ghana showing the appropriation and utilisation of the sums granted by Parliament to meet the public expenditure of the Government, and other accounts laid before Parliament.”

Whether they are performance audits or not, they are all public expenditure of Government. So, it is very clear. I do not think this is something that we should argue about. The Standing Orders are clear; the Constitution is clear. Unless we

want to review the Constitution and take it to the Constitutional Review Committee that the President has set up. But currently, the Standing Orders are clear and the Constitution is also clear.

Mr Speaker, respectfully, let us refer it to the appropriate Committee which the Standing Orders and the Constitution say is the Public Accounts Committee.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Deputy Minority Whip before Majority Leader.

First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu): Mr Speaker, just to add to what the Chairperson of the Public Accounts Committee said, the Committees that the Majority Leader is referring to, even though they have oversight, they can go on working visits, look at the Reports and that is oversight.

Mr Speaker, but to say that they should be added to the Public Accounts, they have oversight and then there is a report and they are going to sit and preside over their own Report and do what? I think it is very clear that it should be referred to the Public Accounts Committee because it is a performance audit. When the Auditor-General finishes his performance, it is the Public Accounts Committee that looks at it, not the Committees. Because the Committees already have a performance oversight on it.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, before making progress, let us look at Order 229 (5). It states:

“For the expeditious consideration and reporting to plenary, the Committee...” that is the Public Accounts Committee, “... may have the following sub-committees:

(a) Sub-Committee on Educational Institution”

Which means that if the audit Report relates to educational institutions, it must be dealt with by the Sub-Committee on Educational Institutions, not the Education Committee. Now:

(b) Sub-Committee on Management and Utilisation of Statutory Funds;

(c) Sub-Committee on Public Accounts;

(d) Sub-Committee on Performance Audit and Foreign Exchange Receipts and Payments;

(e) Sub-Committee on Monitoring and Implementation; and

(f) any other sub-committee that the Committee may determine.”

So, if this is directly, for instance, under the Committee on Education, why would a Public Accounts Committee set up a sub-Committee responsible for educational institutions?

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, you know, as Chairperson of the Independent Constitutional Bodies, the Auditor-General’s office is within our

purview, and I believe you were with me when we undertook a visit to the Auditor-General’s office. We had a discussion there where the Auditor-General explained to us that they are actually going beyond just financial audits to actual delivery audits. So, for instance, if a road contract is awarded and you are supposed to perform it up to a certain standard, the value that you are supposed to deliver, it is because the Auditor-General’s office does not have capacity that they are unable to help us as a Parliament to actually give us a report on value for money. But when they build their capacity, they can actually go beyond just financial audits to actual performance of the contract, whether the building has been built up to the specifications, the quantum of cement, roofing, iron rods, the electricals and everything has been done so that we can get the quantities that have been paid for. That is another level of auditing. It is because they do not have capacity that they have not been doing that and audits have been focusing on financial expenditure; did the person spend the money or not? Has it been receipted or not? And we all watch the work of the Public Accounts Committee, and it is all about financials. The money that was spent, was it spent? Have the receipts been provided? Has it been accounted for and *et cetera*? Not whether value was attained. That is a higher level of auditing.

The point that I am making is that when you look at our Standing Orders, it was designed with financial auditing in mind, not actual value delivery by the agencies. And I am saying that when it

comes to actual value delivery beyond the finances, the sector Committees should be interested—*[Interruption]*—But that is the point. The Committees themselves do not have the levels of capacity that the Auditor-General's Office will have in terms of assessment of value delivered. So, since the Auditor-General's Office is actually a servant of Parliament, the Auditor-General's Office is meant for Parliament; to help us to audit and report to us, so that we can then do our oversight using the information that they have provided.

I am saying that going forward, when it comes to performance of Ministries and not financial audits, it should go to the sector sub-committees. That is the argument that I am making. That in this instance, these are performance-related reports which should go to the Committees— *[Interruption]* — Yes, because, the Auditor-General's Report, my argument is, there are two types of Reports that they could present. The Report on the finance, how the money was spent. Then there is also a Report on the actual delivery of value. And I am saying that the two are different. If it is the finances, the Public Accounts Committee is the one that should look at it. But if it is performance, I think that the sector Committees should take it.

Even if we do not want the sector Committees to take it, I think the Leadership of the sector Committee should join the Public Accounts Committee so that they can see the extent to which actual delivery is taking place in their sectors.

Otherwise, the Public Accounts Committee is sitting there. They were not involved in the debates. They were not involved in the analysis that went into the allocations to the various institutions. So, they do not get the kind of information that you get from an audit report to evaluate their own sectors. I heard the Hon Member say that they on their own should go to the field in pursuit of their oversight responsibility and find out whether the toilets were built and whether they were built up to standard and *et cetera*.

4.12 p.m.

That is what I hear him saying and I am saying that they could also be held by the Auditor-General having gone to the field, having seen the buildings and now present a report to Parliament. The sector committee should have access to that report and participate in evaluating that report. That is my argument.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I always indicate that if the farm is not far, your water container must not be big. So, this is not a matter that we should debate for a very long time. I am clear in my mind that the referral to the Public Accounts Committee is correct.

Mr Nitiwul: Mr Speaker, I just want to correct some impression which I did not say. I said that the ministries prepare and present to Parliament performance reports. Those are referred to the committees, but any report that comes from the Auditor-General should be referred to the Public Accounts Committee. It does not matter whatever

it is. Once the Auditor-General is allowed to send external auditors to audit and bring the report to Parliament, it should be to the Public Accounts Committee and so we should let Public Accounts Committee deal with it. But once the Ministry prepares performance reports, that has to go to the sector committees, and they should do justice to it.

So, whether they want to see the toilets or whatever, it should reflect in the performance reports. They want to see the roads constructed or whatever, it should reflect in the performance reports. With that one, the Public Accounts Committee has nothing to do with performance audits and every ministry has to bring its performance audit here and lay it. Once it is laid which is normally done, it should be done, not the Ministers. Some were even laid last week. It is referred to the appropriate committee and the committee should do justice to it. But once the Auditor-General is allowed to present his report, if it is referred to the committee again, it will not be in order. We will be introducing something we have never done as a Parliament. But Mr Speaker, I think your ruling is in order.

Thank you very much.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let us read Order 229(3). Mr Speaker, just for the exercise that we are involved in, Order 229(3) says;

(3) Pursuant to article 187 (2) and (5) of the Constitution, the Public Accounts Committee shall examine the report of the Auditor-General on the public accounts of Ghana showing the appropriation and utilisation of the sums granted by Parliament to meet the public expenditure of the Government, and other accounts laid before Parliament.

I listened to the Hon Member – I do not know if he listened to himself – but in his presentation, he said that where it is a performance audit, it should go to the sector.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: No

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I heard him. He said it. I paid attention, he said it. You can play the tape again. [*Uproar*]

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, what he said is that if it is a performance report, then the performance report would go to the sector committee, but if it is the audit performance report, then the audit performance report should go to the public accounts. So, there is a distinction between performance report and audit performance report.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the point I am making is that the Auditor-General is now moving beyond just examination of accounts and they are going into actual performance audits. What is the difference between a performance audit of the Auditor-General and a performance report of the sector

Minister? Maybe I should be educated on that by people in the accounting field.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon former Minister, you have the floor.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, just to provide some information to help. For example, when you talk of the audit performance reports, a Ministry, a department or agency may be allocated an amount of money to, let us say, build a number of schools. The audit of the accounts will be to examine whether the accounting practices and principles that have been applied will represent what they call in auditing a true and fair view of what the situation may be. Then when it comes to performance, they want to actually inspect and count and be sure that these schools have been built. They are both functions of audit.

It is very different from the Annual Performance Reports (APRs) that are prepared by the ministries in conjunction with the National Development Planning Committee (NDPC). Actually, the ministries do not just do it themselves, they do it in conjunction with the NDPC. And for those ones, they are focused on determining inputs, Key Performance Indicators (KPIs), outputs and impact. So, you will notice that those APRs are not exactly the same that the auditors prepare. Those are the ones that go to the sector committees, which the Hon former Minister for Defence is referring to. But the audit ones, be they about the accounting of the buildings or on the accounts, they are both to go to the Public Accounts Committee.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us make progress. I think we have presented the Papers. We are done with the (a) and (b).

Hon Majority Leader, are we doing the (c)?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think we can take a few Statements that you have admitted.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Very well. The Second Deputy Speaker should take the Chair.

Hon Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, we have had these two Motions pending for over two weeks, Motion 16 and Motion 15. I do not know whether, as the Second Deputy Speaker takes the Chair, we are going to continue with the debate on the Motion numbered 16. As for that of the Motion numbered 15, it has not been moved at all.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Well, regarding these two Motions, I do not have clear instructions from the Rt Hon Speaker so maybe I will have to confer with him.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well, Mr Speaker, but I pray that the Clerks-at-the-Table will be minded by the urgency of these Motions, as stated by Mr Speaker himself, to draw our attention. Because the Mid-Year Budget Review

will soon come and this matter is a nagging matter.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, these are Motions that he wants to take himself so I believe appropriately he will do so.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I agree with you, but I am saying that the Clerks-at-the-Table have a duty. This is not a matter really for you, though you have taken it upon yourself to pursue. But Mr Speaker, it is your matter that we are appealing, and you are being very magnanimous by saying that you would remind the Speaker. But it is the Clerks-at-the-Table who must remind the Speaker to make time for this one. But, Mr Speaker, with Motion 15, I do not think that one has any big problem at all. I do not know why our Friends opposite are running away from this all-important Motion. I do not know why they are running away, because the Chief Whip of the Majority Caucus seems not interested in this all-important Motion that seeks to enrich the jurisprudence of this House. Mr Speaker, this is a Motion that he should take interest in.

4.22 p.m.

So, I do not know why the avant-garde of Government Business appears not interested.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Minority Leader, are you aware the Speaker would want to take those Motions himself?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, it is our duty as Leaders to

encourage that to happen, so I am appealing to him; he has a duty.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: But my question is not answered, are you aware?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Chief Whip of Government has a duty to work with the Minority in approaching the Speaker. I am a co-sponsor; look at the Motion.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us make progress.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The Motion has joint applicants.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Let us make progress.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Well, Mr Speaker, this is an important matter. It has been delayed for over two weeks—*[Interruption]*—So is it not the Business of the House? I do not know why the Majority Side is running away from these Motions.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have two Statements. We have a Statement on the International Day of Parliamentarianism, standing in the name of Hon Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah, Member of Parliament for the Ho West, and Chairman of the Open Government Partnership (OGP) Caucus in Parliament.

Then we have another Statement standing in the name of Hon Patricia Appiagyei, calling for national support for the Black Queens ahead of the

Confederation of African Football (CAF) Women's African Cup of Nations.

Hon Patricia Appiagyei, you have the floor.

4.26 p.m. — [MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER IN THE CHAIR]

STATEMENTS

National Support for the Black Queens Ahead of the CAF Women's Africa Cup of Nations

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I rise today to draw Parliament's and the nation's attention to our Black Queens, Ghana's senior women's national football team, who are currently in Morocco preparing for the upcoming Confederation of African Football (CAF) Women's African Cup of Nations. Ghana's Black Queens embodies not only sporting talents, but are also national ambassadors who display resilience, ambition, and gender equity.

Mr Speaker, whereas the Black Stars, Ghana's senior men's team, have traditionally enjoyed abundant physical and financial support, the same cannot be said of our Black Queens. The Black Queens have consistently delivered outstanding performances, often surpassing expectations, and have achieved remarkable milestones with meagre resources in their international engagements.

Mr Speaker, it is important to emphasise that the Black Queens were the first senior national team to qualify Ghana for a FIFA World Cup when they earned their place at the 1999 FIFA Women's World Cup in the United States. This historic achievement preceded Ghana's Black Stars World Cup qualification in 2006.

In the Women's Africa Cup of Nations, the Black Queens have been runners-up three times: 1998, 2002, and 2006. They have qualified for the tournament 12 times since its inception in 1998. Over the past year, the Black Queens built significant momentum, scoring 34 goals and conceding only two, recording 10 wins in 11 matches, and establishing themselves as a formidable force in African women's football. The team has recently demonstrated renewed focus and determination through preparatory friendly matches, securing a 3-1 victory over Malawi and a 4-2 win over Benin. These are not minor milestones; they are compelling evidence that when given the opportunity, our women excel beyond measure.

Today, Mr Speaker, we are privileged to live in an era where, for the first time in Ghana's history, the Vice President of the Republic is a woman. This is not just a symbolic milestone; it is an emphatic signal that women empowerment is no longer an aspirational rhetoric but a national commitment.

In July 2024, the Eighth Parliament passed the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 (Act 1121), affirming

our collective resolve to institutionalise gender equity across all spheres of public and private endeavour. The passage of this legislation means the empowerment of Ghanaian women must move from verbal commitments to visible action, and it must be demonstrated in every sector, including sports.

Our Black Queens deserve the same level of national support, visibility and investment that have traditionally been accorded to their male counterparts. This is not merely a matter of fairness but a strategic imperative to inspire young girls across our country and strengthen Ghana's global reputation.

Mr Speaker, it will interest the House to know that the United States Women's National Team is the most successful because of the strategic attention and investments made towards the team over the years by the country.

Accordingly, Mr Speaker, I wish to respectfully call on the Minister for Sports and Recreation to prioritise all necessary logistical, technical, financial and motivational support to ensure that Black Queens represent Ghana with dignity and confidence.

We also call on corporate organisations, development partners and well-meaning Ghanaians to increase investments and financial support for the Black Queens.

Also, we call on the media to raise awareness and whip up enthusiasm for the Black Queens campaign. Our commitments and citizens should rally

behind the team and demonstrate visibly, support across all platforms to encourage them to rise to the occasion.

Mr Speaker, true empowerment is measured by the depth of our investments in women's potential and the seriousness with which we match our commitments with action. This is our moment to show that when we say our time is now, it is a time that includes our women. Let us rally behind the Black Queens and ensure they return not only as competitors but as champions who had the full backing of a grateful nation, Ghana, for that matter.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

4.32 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member for South Tongu, let us hear you. It should not be more than five minutes.

Ing Surv Kwame Maxwell Lukutor (NDC — South Tongu): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the Statement ably made by the Deputy Minority Leader.

I must say that it is necessary we pay close attention to our women, especially in football. Of course, it is said that what men do, women do better, but I dare to say it is not significant when it comes to football. I particularly pay attention to the women team, especially when they are playing, not necessarily because they are doing better than the men on the field of play, but because it makes it more

interesting to watch the women play. Sometimes I wonder whether they are women or men and it makes it very interesting —*[Interruption]*— No, I meant their approach to the game is not seen in a very feminine manner but very combative. Yes, that was what I said.

I want to say that the hue and cry we hear usually after the tournaments of unpaid allowances is so loud and sometimes, one hears that they are lodged in hostels and the threat is that, until they are paid their bonuses, they will not leave the hostels. I believe that, like she said, we should give them more attention like we do to the men. The call for corporate organisations to come to our aid and support our women is very apt because we see most of them drifting towards the Black Stars and the male-dominated teams. So, I believe that corporate Ghana should also come to the aid of the women and make sure they support them.

On this note, I want to, Mr Speaker, congratulate the team that is doing so well and it is our prayer that when they get to the Women's Africa Cup of Nations, they do better than they did in the last tournament. Let me pay glowing tributes to a few of them: Doris Boaduwa, Stella Nyamekye, Princess Marfo, Princella Adubea, Evelyn Badu, Grace Asantewaa, Comfort Yeboah, Kerrie McCarthy, Afi Amenyeku, Azumah Bugre and especially, Blessing Shine Agbomadzi, who comes from my community in Kpotave in the South Tongu Constituency. Let me say that she is doing so well and we pray that she continues to lift the banner and the name of South Tongu higher.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity and I thank the Deputy Minority Leader for a good job done.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me go to the Hon Member for Okere.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP — Okere): Thank you, Mr Speaker and I want to commend my Deputy Leader for this clarion call.

Mr Speaker, if you look at modern records, by far, the Black Queens are doing better than the Black Stars because they have been able to qualify for the African Cup of Nations. This clarion call by Hon Appiagyei is something that we must take seriously because we pay so much attention to the Black Stars to the neglect of their female counterparts. Meanwhile, statistics that she read indicate that these young ladies are doing very well.

Generally, we all ought to pay particular attention to women in sports, so, using the Black Queens, they need the support. We do not see the usual euphoria that would have come if it were the male counterparts who were participating in this tournament. I think that the media also need to step up their game in promoting the Black Queens and all of us should get involved because these young ladies are doing very well and it is important that we do not just let these young ladies down. We should also build successive teams and pay attention to these academies and these colts' teams, which are nurturing these young women in their various communities. I

believe that when we pay special attention to our women in sports, we would be able to advance the course of sports and football in this country and not only the male counterparts.

Let us all get involved, as even parliamentarians, community leaders and then the National Sports Authority. I trust my good Friend, who is now the Director-General, Mr Ampofo Ankrah, and his team to be able to upgrade their game in terms of the promotion of the Black Queens, so that they can do better and bring gold home.

With these few words, I conclude, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, I will come to you for the concluding part.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not contributing, but this is a Statement coming from no less a person than the Deputy Minority Leader. She is a woman; I would strongly suggest that we yield to the women in this Chamber to comment on this matter.

Mr Speaker, the first comment came from a male. The second also came from another male and the third is another male. The women are here. They should rise to the occasion and comment on this matter because this is about promoting their gender in sports.

The fact that they have been failed in Government's appointment does not mean they should —[Laughter]— Yes, Mr Speaker, the President promised 30

per cent. If we look at the Cabinet, only about two women are in Cabinet. If we see all the chief executive officer (CEO) appointments, few are women. We have women in this Chamber. Even as board chairs, a lot of the women in this Chamber have not been recognised: Hon Member for Salaga South and Hon Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings. We know all the women in this Chamber.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, let me listen to your Colleague.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the point is that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Your point is well made.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I need to conclude. This Statement is coming from a female colossus, Madam Patricia Appiagyei, a former Mayor of Kumasi, former Deputy Minister, former Deputy Majority Leader, and now, Deputy Minority Leader and we do not want to give women the chance to contribute. It is clear that our women have been boxed into a tight corner. Even in Government, we are seeing a few women being considered. Look at the Deputy Ministerial appointments: no Deputy Ministers for Communication, Digital Technology and Innovation; Transport; and Foreign Affairs. What is the Government waiting for?

Mr Speaker, I will rest my case. This is not a time to debate. When the Statement of Hon Bedzrah comes, that is where we are going to deal with this

issue of gender equity. I have seen his Statement and it is all about gender equity. So, I will rest my case on this matter.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am even struggling with how to interrupt him. He is neither debating nor commenting.

Mr Speaker, is the Minority Leader suggesting that the women in this Chamber belong to only the Majority Caucus? That cannot be; there are women who are backing him — *[Interruption]*— No, his statement suggested that it is only women from our Side who supposedly — So, first of all, as a Leader, he ought not to speak in that manner.

Then, the suggestion that women are being boxed into a corner cannot also be correct. Our women — and I know the women even on his Side — always rise to the occasion just like now when the Deputy Minority Leader has simply issued a Statement and we have been given the opportunity to comment on it. So, he cannot suggest that the women have been boxed into a corner.

So, the Minority Leader, with all due respect, is completely out of order. The women will rise to the occasion and they will prove that they will rise to the occasion with this Statement. With the next one that will come, again, they will rise to the occasion.

Mr Speaker, let me take my seat, so that you give the women the opportunity to have a bite on this matter.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, you raised a fundamental. I am going to give the women the opportunity.

4.42 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is a house of records. When the Majority Chief Whip rose, I thought he was going to rebut a statement regarding the number of women in Government. No, he was loudly silent on that important matter. The President brought the list of his Ministers here and only two women are in Cabinet. The President is appointing board chairpersons, but few are women. The Deputy Ministerial appointments—We have many women on their Side. The President cannot cross and appoint from this Side. They have 40 women in their Government and in this Parliament; just two have made it to Cabinet.

Mr Speaker, this is a serious matter. This is a Government that is not committed to gender equity. Look at even the Committees. How many women are in Committee leadership on their Side? This is a serious matter; we cannot take it for granted. How many women are in Government? How many women have been appointed as Chief Executive Officers (CEOs)? In the National Democratic Congress (NDC) Government, how many women have been relegated to the background? If they have evidence that they have appointed

more women, they should rebut me. This is a house of records.

Mr Speaker, I rest my case.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have the first female Vice President of the Republic of Ghana. [*Hear! Hear!*]—It came from us. For the records, we have a female Deputy Chief of Staff. We have female Ministers of State. We have females appointed as Mayors and Metropolitan Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs). Per our practice and our Rules, when one makes a comment and he is being rebutted, the Member needs not leave the Chamber—[*Laughter*]—but I have seen that the Minority Leader cannot take the punches, so he has absconded from the Chamber. I pray that he returns.

Mr Speaker, that said, may we return to the Business that presently affronts us, so that Members can be given the opportunity to make comments on the Statement. The Minority Leader should return to the Chamber.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: My Brother, now, the discussion is that I should focus on the ladies, so just hold on. Let me first and foremost give the opportunity to the Hon Member for Salaga South.

Ms Zuwera Mohammed Ibrahimah (NDC — Salaga South): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, before I say anything regarding the Statement, I just want this

House to note that the men who stood up to speak for women just succeeded in disrupting the activities of the Chamber. I am sure if they had allowed you space, by now three or four women would have spoken to the very important Statement made by the Deputy Minority Leader. Mr Speaker, I will urge you, in the future, please, allow us to fight our own fight. The men are just here doing politics and filibustering. We want to speak to the issues.

Mr Speaker, on the issue of the Statement, thank you for the opportunity to comment and let me commend my Senior, my mentor, and one of the most accomplished women politicians of this country. The Deputy Minority Leader has written her name in the history of this country, so for her to stand today to make this Statement on behalf of the Black Queens is a testimony of her continued strive to put women issues on the forefront of the agenda of this country and I commend her highly for the Statement. Those of us at the back keep looking up to her. We watch her closely, we listen to her, we pay attention to everything that she does and we try to emulate her.

Mr Speaker, the issue she has raised is a very important issue and although she has raised it within the context of support and effective sponsorship for the women football team, I also think that she has done so because she knows that the Black Queens team has promise and prospects and if we paid attention to them, they might probably be the black team of Ghana that will deliver us a gold at the continental or world level. I want

to assure the maker of the Statement that we have imbibed—Especially the data that she said, she just honed it home and it is something that we all need to think about and look at how to address it.

I will suggest that maybe in the future or if it is not too late—because I think I saw that the tournament is starting on 5th July, if I am right—maybe, the Women Caucus could have paid the team a visit in their camp to reassure them, to relate and engage them, so that they know that we are keeping an eye on what they are doing. When we wait till they get to the front of the tournament and we speak on their behalf, it might not yield the same results as a local engagement here would have.

Mr Speaker, the second thing I want to say, is the issue of sponsorship to ensure that the team is well-resourced and well-prepared and still the Women Caucus in this Parliament can lead such an effort. The Women Caucus can become patrons of the female soccer team in this country and lead the effort with corporate Ghana to raise funds to support this team. We know the situation where when it gets to the Ministry of Sports and Recreation, it is either budgets have not been released or there is not enough money. Let us take the course; let us walk the talk. Let us go out there to corporate Ghana and tell them that we need these women to perform and excel at the world level and I am sure we will have financiers to enable the Black Queens to give off their best at the tournament.

Mr Speaker, last but not the least, last year, the Rt Hon Speaker organised a

football tournament for the Parliamentary Week Celebration. I think I was supposed to be the goalkeeper, but by the time I got there, someone had worn my jersey. So, I became the number nine and I nearly scored a goal.

Mr Speaker, so, I am speaking to my aunty, Ms Patricia Appiagyei, that some of us would want to go to Morocco to cheer the team up. Let us put it together. Let us work on that and get the women out there to go and cheer the Black Queens in Morocco. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me go to the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection.

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Ms Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP): Mr Speaker, thank you very much and let me also take the opportunity to thank the Hon Deputy Minority Leader for the Statement made in support of the Black Queens.

Today, as we sit, before I go into the details of it, I just want to thank the Minority Leader for his concern for women empowerment. However, I just want to also add that the issues around women empowerment—In fact, if we have equity or equality, we would not even be seated here to pass laws and policies being approved for us to get more women into leadership positions, but because we do not have, that is why

we are all making the effort to get more women into leadership positions.

What I will say is that today, as we speak, His Excellency has promised and pledged and there is every indication that he is working towards that pledge. For the first time, in fact, it has taken us over 60 years after independence for us to have the first female Vice President and for us to say, “Her Excellency” is one of the achievements of this country. We hope that as time goes on, we will have more and more women in leadership positions. We applaud you for supporting us.

4.52 p.m.

However, the issue of gender equality is not just about ticking the box. We want the women where it matters most. We do not want to just add to the numbers and say that they want 20 women. I am saying we do not just—We are getting 20 women because we have to get 20 women. But we also want to get the women in the critical areas that matter the most. So, in addition to fighting for women to get into leadership positions, we are also looking at the critical areas that we are placing women; I think that is the fight. There is nothing too strange about that. It is not just about ticking the box, but it is about ensuring that we are putting our money where our heart is. And that is the critical thing I want us to do.

We have also said that football unites the nation, so it will be good that beyond the Statements we make, as part of the efforts, we will see ourselves, not just the

Women’s Caucus, but the whole of Parliament and Mr Speaker, your good office, to join us to go and motivate our women footballers. It will be a good thing for them to see us all together, knowing that we are cheering them. And this is the only time that we do not want to also say that because it is the women, only the women should play. We are saying that gender issues are national issues. So, Mr Speaker, if my Hon Minority Leader thinks that we should come together, which is the concern for us all, I think that he should also provide leadership and say that today, let the Minority and the Majority Sides come together and move to where the women are and motivate them. I am sure corporate organisations will also come together and follow us. We want women on every bench. Every bench of leadership, we want women there. And we want women most at the critical areas of this nation as well. His Excellency John Dramani Mahama has shown the way and I believe that all of us will follow suit.

In concluding, I am just trying to say that let us start from the known to the unknown. Let us do the little things with coming into force of the Affirmative Action Act, to put in every little effort to ensure that we increase the numbers and even more so at where it matters most.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Let me go to the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture Development, who is also a woman.

Mrs Emelia Arthur (NDC — Shama): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

While commending the maker of the Statement and aligning myself with the virtuous attributes that have been assigned to her by previous speakers, I would like to emphasise the fact that it is important that we support women in all endeavours. Even the name of the female football team, Black Queens, suggests that we see something in them and therefore, the nation must support such endeavours. It is not just about kicking a ball on a field of play; It is about courage. It is about ability and capacity. And therefore, it is important that we recognise all that.

May I put on record as well that the women on this Side, to the extent that one speaks in support of womanhood, we appreciate the comments of the Minority Leader. But we also want to state that we do not need anybody to speak for us. We are strong women; we are women of valour. We went through the electoral process just like any man in this Chamber and we can stand up for ourselves and speak for ourselves.

The other thing is that I sit in Cabinet, and when I look around, I see more than two women in Cabinet. I also want us to put on record that there are a lot of women who have been appointed. And of course, there is room for more, so, when the point is made, it is appreciated. But it is not to be put in a state as if nothing has been done or just little has been done. Of course, as women

advocates and women activists, we want more. We want to see more of us in the spaces that matter.

When we talk about gender, it is not about woman or man. It is about the relationships between men and women, and especially around discourses and decisions that share resources between these genders. So, when we talk about that, it is important that we look at what is being allocated to deal with women's issues versus what is being allocated to deal with men's issues.

I stand, Mr Speaker, to support the maker of the Statement and looking at it broadly, it should not only focus on women in sports, but it should focus on women along the different strata— Women are not a homogeneous group; We are different groups of women. So, we should look at support for women across the different strata so that together we move this economy and this country, because it is doable.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Let me come to Leadership.

All right, let me listen to Hon Gloria Owusu first, then I come to Leadership.

Ms Gloria Owusu (NPP — Trobu): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

I rise to support the Statement by Hon Patricia Appiagyei. Mr Speaker, the

Black Queens are doing so well and we must support them in the way that we can as a country. Mr Speaker, when you come to my Constituency, Trobu, we have a lot of women doing well. — *[Interruption]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Gloria Owusu, address me.

Ms Owusu: Mr Speaker, when you come to Trobu Constituency, we have a lot of women doing well in sports and I will urge the Minister for Sports and Recreation and the Ghana Football Association to support women in sports because they get little support.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

I will give the opportunity to another woman.

Hon Edem, no, today is not your time.

Yes, Hon Member for Nsuta?

Ms Adelaide Ntim (NPP — Nsuta/Kwaman Beposo): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I would like to comment on the Statement by the Deputy Minority Leader, Hon Patricia Appiagyei.

Mr Speaker, we need to motivate the Black Queens so that they can do more. The Government needs to support them

financially and encourage them. The Ghanaian women especially also need to motivate them and remember them in prayers so that they will have more ego to work for Mother Ghana.

I thank you, Mr Speaker, for this great opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

The last lady, the Hon Member for Atiwa East.

Mrs Abena Osei-Asare (NPP — Atiwa East): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I would like to thank the maker of the Statement for bringing to the fore the role of women in sports. I would also like to encourage the Black Queens and let them know that the sky is not even their limit, there is more they can do. I would also tell Government to consistently resource them to enable them take advantage of proper training and other things that they will need to help them succeed. It is not just about the men, but also the women. These days we have women's league all around the world and I would be very happy if the Ghana Football Association would think of coming up with a women's league as it is done in other places because that would be a rich resource for human capacity development that can feed into our Black Queens.

5.02 p.m.

So, on this note I would like to thank the maker of the Statement once again and wish our Black Queens, coach and the whole team a success and that we are solidly behind them. We pray and hope that something better will come out of this. Thank you very much Mr Speaker for the opportunity.

Some Hon Members — rose —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, let me now turn to—No, I cannot. I have to allow the Hon Member for Dormaa East. Yes, Hon Member, let us hear you.

Ms Rachel Amma Owusuah (NDC — Dormaa East): Thank you Mr Speaker for giving me the opportunity. I would want to commend Hon Patricia Appiagyei, my mentor, for making such a beautiful Statement.

Mr Speaker, though a Bill has been passed for equity and equality, the anatomy and physiology of women make it a bit difficult to achieve our aim as women in sports. Congratulations to the able ladies for forming the team. Therefore, I will encourage the Black Queens on their efforts and their devotion. I wish them good luck, so that they come home with victory to make the nation proud. Thank you, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will now turn to Leadership. Yes, Minority Leader?

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, let me thank Hon Patricia Appiagyei for bringing to the fore this important Statement.

Mr Speaker, women need support, be it in academia, in the area of sports or governance. They need to be supported, recognised and offered equal opportunity. It is through offering them such equal opportunities that we can evaluate their capacity to do the work and then know what talent they have. Mr Speaker, looking at our Constitution, for instance, Article 78, and I would want your leave to read and do so aloud. Article 78 (1) says:

“Ministers of State shall be appointed by the President with the prior approval of Parliament from among members of Parliament or persons qualified to be elected as members of Parliament, except that the majority of Ministers of State shall be appointed from among members of Parliament.

So, Mr Speaker, I am, adding my voice to the earlier submission by my respected Colleague who is also the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection. In her earlier submissions, she underscored the fact that women are required in critical areas and not just to add to the numbers. Mr Speaker, I find this extremely curious and rich. This Statement, without misconstruing its effects, is suggesting that, for instance, this constitutional provision that requires majority of Ministers to be appointed from Parliament does not matter.

When I raised the point earlier that there are fewer women in this Government, especially when it came to the ministerial appointment, we have her, the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection, the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture, Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts and the Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry out of the lot, when the Constitution says majority of Ministers must come from Parliament. Mr Speaker, at the Cabinet level, there are so many Ministers that were appointed but there are just these four out of 40. It is of great concern and does not show a government that is committed to gender equity. It is not as if the talent is not there and that the women are not available; they are.

Let me move from the Cabinet level or the mainstream ministerial appointment and come to even the Deputies. How many Deputies made it? Only a handful. A lot of them are here, and looking at their credentials, the minimum we would find is a second degree for quite a lot of them. So, Mr Speaker, it is of grave concern, and I am sure if the Hon Member who is also the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection had paid due regard to my submissions, she would not have said the Government is not interested in adding to the numbers. Mr Speaker, if looking at even the Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Chief Executive (MMDCE) appointment, we have 260 that have been appointed, only 28 are women. Well, rebut me. How many then?

Mr Speaker, again, look at the enactment on gender equity, Act 1121, it

makes clear what is expected of government. It is a different agreement if the women are not available in this Chamber. The Constitution talks about majority coming from Parliament, we have an enactment that is calling on government to at least look at 30 per cent. Can we say that we have met this 30 per cent threshold required of us by the law; a law passed by the people's representatives and we cannot talk about it? We should talk about it.

If I look at the credentials of the 40 women Members of Parliament on the Majority Side, all of them have the essential credentials to make it to that very top. What is happening? So, Mr Speaker, we cannot do wishy-washy on this matter. We did not find them in the key ministerial appointments. Even the Chief Executive Officer (CEO) appointment and the board, we are not finding the women. If they could not make it for them —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minority Leader, I think the Statement was on women's football.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, but you heard the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection talk about the appointments. I am just adding up the points.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I can appreciate what we are talking about.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Very well. Mr Speaker, I speak genuinely. So, Mr Speaker, all I want to put across is that whilst the maker of the Statement is

inviting this House to acknowledge the contribution of women and that women must be supported, we should not limit it only to the area of sports. We should see such recognition of women and what they can do in government as well. We should pay attention to other areas. That is the point I want to underscore; that is the burden of my call, that in this very House, we have enacted a law that allows us to create equal opportunity. In fact, the principle of equal opportunity is even a constitutional *bona fide*. So, we do not even need an enactment.

5.12 p.m.

So, we ask ourselves, to what extent have we respected this? We have 40 women sitting to the right of the Speaker on the NDC Side and when appointments are made, they have all been ignored; only a handful have been appointed. How can we have the Hon Member for Essikadu-Ketan, a professor in this House and she has not been seen? It is not possible.

Mr Speaker, I would want to encourage all stakeholders who support gender equity to rise to the occasion and support our women. I am told they will play against Morocco on Friday. They need all our support. Members of Parliament must be the lead cheerleaders in this matter, and I am sure through such encouragement, they would also do their best for their country.

To the Black Queens, I say I wish them well. They may not have the needed resources, but they should be inspired by

their sense of patriotism and make Ghana proud.

Mr Speaker, I shall rest my case without saying more, having made sufficient points on this important matter. I pray that Government would have a second look at the Constitution and the enactment, and do the needful.

Mr Speaker, I do not know why the Majority Leader is so anxious to respond to me this Chamber. Mr Speaker, he has the women who are capable. He has many women who can respond to me. Hon Doyoe is here. The last time I raised an important matter, Hon Doyoe was at hand to address the issues. Why is the Majority Leader so anxious on this occasion? Mr Speaker, it is his right; if he wants to respond, so be it. But I know I have raised fundamental points.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection would like to make some corrections.

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP): Mr Speaker, respectfully, I do not mean to give a rebuttal, but because this House is a house of records, I would humbly like to correct this — I never said His Excellency was not interested in appointing women. I said and gave examples that, beyond just taking and appointing this number of women, he is

looking at the critical areas where these women who are appointed would be placed. So, I humbly want this record to be corrected. I mentioned that I appreciate his concerns, but beyond his concerns, we are also looking at empowerment at critical areas. So, I said including looking at the numbers, we are also looking to place women at areas where our voices matter the most. That is what I said and I am sure the records bear me out.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Majority Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Thank you very much. As for my Brother, the Minority Leader, he has suddenly become a major gender advocate, but when he was made Leader, his Side had 20 women. Today, he has only 10 women. *[Laughter]* He could not defend even the 20 women that were given to him as Leader. He lost half of them. Today, he has only 10 women and he is the one who is pontificating about gender and women being protected and appointed when he could not even defend the 20 that were given to him.

As a Majority Leader and Leader of Government Business with his Government in power, he had all the resources and he could not defend the women. He lost half of the women. Today, he is here telling us about the need to defend women and to ensure the women are protected in office and appointed to offices. My late President said, *Dzi wo fie asem*. He should fix the problem in his house and protect the

women in his house before he comes to do advocacy for the women on this Side.

Mr Speaker, on that note, let me also join them to encourage our women. I was the Minister for Sports at one point and I know that the struggle for women to be given fair treatment so that they can realise their full potential in the area of football has been a long-drawn one, but they are making a lot of progress. I recall that the year we were participating in the World Cup in Canada, I flew into the United States of America (U.S.A) and connected to Canada, drove straight to the airport just to be there for our women national team for the opening match. And immediately the match ended, I drove back to the airport, took a flight and came back to Ghana. So, I was in Canada for barely four hours just to support our women because they were complaining that when they are playing, we do not show support. I think over the years, they have enjoyed quite some support. I also think that there have been some reforms in terms of the bonuses to bring them to a reasonable level. What is needed is for us to continue to encourage and support them.

I am part of a team that is working very closely with the Minister for Sports and Recreation to engage in some fundraising to support football. I believe that when we are able to raise the kind of financing that we are looking at, we will be able to give the national teams the support that they need. Two weeks ago, when Cabinet met, Cabinet approved that the Minister for Sports and Recreation should work hard to raise funds and establish a sports fund that will

be able to support football and also our women in football.

Now I just want to address a few issues that the Minority Leader raised. I do not have the exact figures, but I know that the number that he mentioned in relation to Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs) is not accurate. They are definitely more than that. We will check the figures and communicate to this House. But I think on the issue of appointments and the percentages, anybody who understands our constitutional architecture knows that one may try very hard, but the base that one is given as a President to work with will definitely be a determinant of how far one can go. For instance, when the President says that he must have 30 per cent Ministers, if he is drawing his Ministers largely from his Parliamentary team and the constituencies do not elect the number of women that he requires into the Parliamentary team, it becomes a constraint. It becomes a constraint to be able to meet that requirement. So, we will continue to work hard.

Let us focus on the political parties. Political parties should try and make sure that in seats that they consider safe, they structure their constitutions in such a way that they are able to guarantee that they will get women to contest. I will not describe Bawku Central as a safe seat. We know that it is a seat that has moved from NDC to NPP. So, they must go to Ashanti Region where the NPP has very safe seats or to the Volta region where NDC has very safe seats. In those areas, for instance, Winneba which is a safe seat of the NPP, we can guarantee that a

woman should be the candidate of the NPP. And she will win and come here.

5.22 p.m.

If they put a female as the candidate for Effutu, she will definitely win—*[Laughter]*—And that will shore up the number of women on their Side. So, I think that if the political parties take decision at the national executive committee level on the use of women candidates in safe and guaranteed seats, we will have a lot more women. But in the very competitive constituencies, when they force a candidate on them and they rebel and they go and vote for independent or vote for a candidate of the opposing party, the party will be in trouble.

So, I believe that the levers are actually in the hands of our political parties; it is at that level that they can create the base that will enable a president to have a large pool out of which to make the kind of appointments that he will need to meet the targets. But why 30 per cent? Because the women are actually statistically more than the men. If one looks at the population of this country there are more women than men. So, if there are more women than men, where is the 30 per cent coming from? On what basis are we saying that there must be a mandatory 30 per cent for a number that is more than 50 per cent when we look at the population of the country?

I think we should begin to advocate for women to also be conscious of the need to support their fellow women when they

contest. When women contest, they should support them and the women should have the courage to contest. If women have the courage to contest, women should vote for them. That is why, next time, a woman should contest the Minority Leader in the primaries—*[Hear! Hear!]*—I do not think that 30 per cent is adequate. The 30 per cent is inequitable in a situation where the women are more than 50 per cent.

So, Parliament even got it wrong. That is my position on the matter and I look forward to the day when we will enter this Chamber and there will be more women than men because that will actually represent the population of this country. And I know that when women are in this Chamber, they even do better representing the interests of men—*[Interruption]*—They will not finish the men—*[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, I do not think there is a basis for being afraid. I do not think that when women populate this Chamber, the men should be worried. They probably would do better managing our economy, security, and social welfare system. Because at home, they do better managing those affairs—*[Hear! Hear!]*—If they do better at home managing those affairs, I am guaranteed that they will do better managing their affairs in this Chamber—*[Hear! Hear!]*—And that is why we should have more women. This is why the National Democratic Congress (NDC), as a political party, insisted on having a woman as the Vice President for the first time in the history of this country. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, I challenge the NPP that, in the next election—I dare them to also put up a woman as a vice-presidential candidate and I know that Ms Appiagye is a strong candidate from the Ashanti Region, starting as a Mayor, a Member of Parliament, a Deputy Minister and, now, a Deputy Leader. She clearly fits to be a running mate—*[Hear! Hear!]*—From the strongest political base of the NPP, she has guaranteed NPP their base. I challenge the NPP that, in the next election, we want to see a woman as their running mate. As for us in the NDC, we can only go forward. Backward, never. Forward, ever.

Thank you Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Hon Minority Leader —*rose*—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, let us take the second Statement. Leader, I beg you—She begs you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not going to debate him.

Mr Speaker, please, just for the record, he is my Colleague. At our level, we are able to settle matters—*[Interruption]*—Yes, but he and I operate at a level which is higher than you, so you have to allow us. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, my respected Colleague, the Majority Leader, said I provided a figure which was not accurate. Meanwhile, he was not ready with what he considered accurate. I would prefer that the aspect of his submission to the effect that what I said was not accurate

be stepped down. If he brings any figure which is higher than 28, I am ready to concede. Meanwhile, he said that they have a Vice President, which is true and it is a fact, but we put a woman as Chief Justice and we are removing her.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I think that nobody has removed the Chief Justice. I think, in this House, we should not prejudice other constitutional processes that are ongoing, so I do not want to comment on that. But I just to say that I think that the number of Metropolitan, Municipal and District Chief Executives (MMDCes) who are women is about 30, not 28.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, if it is 30 and not 28, I take it. I checked and it was 28, but he is the Leader of Government Business. If he says it is 30, I will concede to the 30 for now and still validate. But, Mr Speaker, that 30 does not change the story. It is very insignificant. Even if it is 30, it does not change the story.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the second Statement is from Mr Emmanuel Bedzrah. He is going to talk on International Day of Parliamentarianism as a Chairman of the Open Government Partnership (OGP) Caucus in Parliament and the Hon Member for Ho West.

Yes, Hon Member?

International Day of Parliamentarianism

Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to make this Statement to mark the International Day of Parliamentarianism, as observed yesterday, 30th June, 2025. This globally recognised day, established by the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) and the United Nations (UN), invites us to reflect on the important role of parliaments in promoting democracy, good governance, accountability, and inclusive representation for all, including women, youth, and minorities.

Mr Speaker, the theme for this year's commemoration of the International Day of Parliamentarianism is "Achieving Gender Equality, Action by Action" emphasising that genuine change is achieved through consistent, everyday efforts by individuals, communities, organisations, and governments. Gender equality is a practical necessity for establishing fair, prosperous, and resilient societies.

Mr Speaker, the theme is apt, as it addresses the perennial issue of the under-representation of women in parliaments worldwide. This is because the lack of gender equality in most parliaments results in a shortage of gender-responsive legislators and policies, which fail to promote participatory democracy and inclusive development.

Although progress has been made worldwide, gender equality remains an ongoing endeavour that requires consistent and deliberate effort at all levels. These barriers not only limit individual potential but also hinder social and economic development.

5.32 p.m.

Let me dispel the mistaken impression that achieving equality means making women more like men or vice versa. That is incorrect. Instead, it is about ensuring that everyone, regardless of gender, has equal opportunities and rights.

Mr Speaker, the Parliament of Ghana has made significant progress in promoting gender equality through legislative policy and institutional reforms. An important milestone is the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024 (Act 1121) which mandates a gradual increase in the representation of women in governance from 30 per cent in 2026 to 50 per cent by the year 2030, along with a gender-responsive budgeting and mechanism for enforcement and accountability. Key institutional efforts include the Women's Caucus which empowers women MPs to advocate for inclusive policies and Ladies in Parliamentary Service (LiPS) which improves visibility and capacity of women within parliamentary structures.

Despite this advancement, considerable challenges remain. Female representation stays low at only 14.6 per cent in 2025, placing Ghana at 137th worldwide. Structural and cultural

barriers, weak enforcement of the Gender Equity Act, and limited civic education impede progress. To address these issues, Parliament must enact more substantial reforms, ensure compliance, and strengthen collaboration with civil society to foster a more gender-inclusive and democratic institution.

The Parliament of Ghana has played a vital role in strengthening democracy, encouraging peaceful political transitions and broadening representation. The 2021 hung Parliament, with equal seats held by both major parties, fostered greater scrutiny of executive action and bipartisan collaboration on legislation and development. Parliament has gained international recognition for its democratic resilience and modernisation efforts, including the adoption of new Standing Orders in 2024.

However, challenges remain. Parliament has sometimes struggled to exercise effective oversight in moments of chaos and misconduct, such as the violence in the Election of Speaker in 2021 and the bipartisan walk outs, have damaged the image of Parliament. Public trust has further weakened by the disconnect between the expectations of the citizens and the legislative role of the MPs, as many Ghanaians prioritise constituency service over lawmaking and oversight. A 2024 survey revealed that only 8 per cent and 2 per cent of citizens value lawmaking and oversight, respectively and stressed the need for increased public education and institutional reforms.

Mr Speaker, it is essential to note that yesterday, while commemorating the day, Parliament also inaugurated the Open Parliament Steering Committee and launched the Open Parliament Action Plan, a timely and strategic step in the effort of Ghana to deepen democratic governance under the Open Government Partnership (OGP).

The Action Plan is structured around four key pillars: transparency, accountability, citizen participation, technology and innovation. It aims to address significant challenges, including limited public access to legislative process, low youth and gender inclusion and inadequate follow-up on parliamentary decisions.

Mr Speaker, since joining the OGP in 2011, Ghana has made notable strides in promoting transparency, accountability, civic participation, and technology-driven governance. Key reforms under the OGP include the Right to Information Act, the 2019 (Act 989), Public Financial Management Act, (2016) (Act 921) and the Office of the Special Prosecutor Act, 2017 (Act 959), among others.

Mr Speaker, more importantly, the inauguration of the OGP Caucus in Parliament, as well as the establishment of the Citizens' Bureau which promotes collaboration between Parliament and Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) have strengthened citizens engagement and increased legislative transparency. The leadership of Ghana in OGP was recognised at a regional meeting in Kenya in March 2025, where Ghanaian

MPs urged counterparts in La Côte d'Ivoire and Benin to initiate their own Open Parliament initiative effort that is now showing promising results.

In 2022, the Parliament of Ghana ranked first in the Open Parliament Index which assessed 13 West African legislatures. The inauguration of the Open Parliament Steering Committee and the launch of a new Action Plan further confirms the commitment of Parliament to openness and inclusive governance. Although challenges persist, the strong collaboration between Parliament and CSOs is set to enhance Ghana's standing in open government through co-creation and collective accountability.

Mr Speaker, as we commemorate this International Day of Parliamentarianism, let us renew our commitment to upholding the principle of parliamentary democracy. Let us work together to build a more accountable, inclusive and effective Parliament that serves the best interests of all Ghanaians and stands as a beacon of democracy on the African continent and beyond.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by way of a guide, if we may take three contributions from each Side.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It would depend on the mood of the House.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Very well, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, I may take one or four each from each Side. It depends on the mood of the House.

Let me start with Hon Shaibu Mahama.

Mr Shaibu Mahama (NDC — Daboya/Mankarigu): Mr Speaker, let me thank you very much for the opportunity and to thank the maker of the Statement, our able Chairman for the OGP, for this important Statement.

Indeed, International Day of Parliamentarianism—Important role of Parliament. This is a very important Statement and it could not have come at a better time. Indeed, the theme is “Achieving Gender Equality, Action by Action”. No doubt, earlier in the afternoon, we got a beautiful Statement from the respected Deputy Minority Leader on women and gender and I think that this statement dovetails into that. Achieving gender equality, action by action.

Mr Speaker, even though we have enacted Act 1121 that talks about gender representation, it is important to note that the milestone that has been given, achieving 30 per cent in 2025 and graduating to 50 per cent in 2030, I think that it is quite a slow pace. My humble view is that we should pursue an aggressive method that will take us to 50 per cent in the next two years and I think that with commitment from Government and other stakeholders, we can achieve this.

Mr Speaker, gender equity is an important topic in every facet of our daily lives and I think it is important that women are given the right opportunity. We talked about football a while ago. The last time we got a trophy from football, Mr Speaker, was four decades ago. Perhaps, the women, the gender, they will be the ones to bring us the next. So, let us encourage that.

5.42 p.m.

Let us move towards achieving 50 per cent in the next two years and not in the next five years. I think that together we can fight to get this done.

Let me thank the maker of the Statement. Indeed, if you look at our current female representation, Mr Speaker, 14.6 per cent is woefully troubling and I do not fault the makers of the Statements when they say we are looking at achieving 30 per cent. It is because the current status is 14.6. I think that as a nation, we should work towards getting this done as quickly as possible. The year 2030 is far too long to achieve 50 per cent.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, hold on, let me listen to the Majority Leader.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, permit me to interrupt the debate and crave your indulgence so that we can lay the Report of the Finance Committee and continue

with the debate so that the Report can be distributed and then we can take the consequential Motions and Resolutions. So, there is an Order Paper *Addendum*.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I do not have.

Mr Ayariga: Order Paper *Addendum*, item numbered 1, Presentation of Instruments by the Chairman of the Finance Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader wants to show us his powers today because the way he is interrupting debate to lay Papers, I do not know where it is coming from.

Mr Speaker, even though we do not have difficulty in laying the Report, the Majority Leader should not be interrupting debates at this time to lay Papers. We have no objection to it, but he should make sure that we have the Report available. We have not seen copies. I could see that Mr Speaker was struggling to even get the Order Paper *Addendum*. The Majority has been doing that; he would arrest the proceedings to lay Bills among others.

So, Mr Speaker, he should make sure that we have enough copies. Since we do not have difficulty, he can go ahead and lay it.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, who is doing us the honours? Yes, Chairman.

PAPERS

By the Chairman of the Committee—

Report of the Finance Committee on the Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Report has been duly presented. It is recommended that the Report be distributed to Hon Members.

So, we go back to the Statement. Hon Member for Okere, you may go on with your comment.

Mr Daniel Nana Addo-Kenneth (NPP — Okere): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for this opportunity. And I want to congratulate the maker of the Statement. I think it has come at the right time.

We are privileged to have been elected by various constituents to be part of this Ninth Parliament. And I believe that this Ninth Parliament presents rare opportunity to cause real change.

Mr Speaker, this year, my emphasis on the theme is action by action in terms of achieving gender equality. For many now, we have all been appreciating the fact that we need gender equality. The Eighth Parliament did well by passing the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024. There is a lot of achievement in terms of establishing the Private Members' Bill and Private Members' Motion Committee. These are all avenues that will go to deepen parliamentary oversight and parliamentary policy making.

Mr Speaker, it is important to note that while Parliament makes policies, the Government of the day starts to implement those policies. However, we have so many gender-sensitive issues. We have indicated that this year and over four years, we intend to put GHC10 billion into the Big Push. This Big Push is supposed to create social infrastructure and alleviate the vulnerable populations which include gender. We have also committed to establishing the Women's Development Bank. All these policies are supposed to alleviate and upgrade the capacities of women and push them to an equality status.

Mr Speaker, today is 1st July. A lot of initiatives have been earmarked to start from 1st July. Unfortunately, Mr Speaker, I have always been making this statement to my Friends and Colleagues on the other Side. And to borrow a phrase, God in his own wisdom, through Ghanaians, have elected an overwhelming majority of parliamentarians. To the extent that this

Parliament, if indeed it is mindful to cause real change, has the capacity to do that without any hindrances.

Mr Speaker, we have over 180 Members of Parliament on the Majority Side. And I have said it to my Friends that Ghanaians should never forgive this Parliament if we are unable to cause real change and if we are unable to play an oversight role in terms of enhancing gender issues. This is a time that we have a clear majority to be able to implement and walk the talk.

Unfortunately, apart from all the achievements we have chalked as Members of Parliament, sometimes as a young Member of Parliament and a first timer, I have always sat here wondering whether we are elected to represent our people or we are supposed to be a mouthpiece of the Government. I have asked several questions on documents that ought to be available for proper scrutiny, so that Members can make informed decisions in enhancing gender equity.

I have had cause to worry that the commitment—And we are talking about action by action, and that is where, Mr Speaker, I want to emphasise my statement that the Big Push that we sought, particularly to elevate women, seven months down the line, we have not seen anything about it.

Mr Speaker, seven months down the line, the Women's Bank which we have touted, we do not have anything to do with it. And the unfortunate thing is that, Mr Speaker, once we activate our oversight, like I did indicate in my earlier

statement, we have Members of Parliament who intend to speak for or question what was done in the past. We have this Parliament to hold accountable, to make sure that we are able to implement some of the policies that will enhance gender equality. This Parliament has a clear majority, and I am reemphasising the fact that Ghanaians will not forgive this Parliament if we are unable to cause real change and if we continue to pay lip service to gender issues.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I will congratulate the maker of the Statement and indicate that as Members of Parliament, we should look more into our oversight responsibility and make sure that we cause real change rather than become spokespersons of the Government.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Lydia Akanvariba Minister of State.

5.52 p.m.

Ms Lydia Lamisi Akanvariba (NDC — Tempone): Thank you, Mr Speaker for the opportunity to comment on this great Statement, and thanks to the maker of this Statement, that calls for an action to gender equity. When we look at the Statement, it tells us that there are inequalities in the system, and that there should be everyday action to make sure that there is equality in the system. So, what are the gender gaps? What calls for the inequalities? One, there are cultural barriers that make it impossible for women to come into the system. Because

in our homes, they will tell us we are women, we are not supposed to do this; women are not supposed to do that. Culturally, they have already put us at a point that we do not know what to do.

Mr Speaker, again, we have difficulties in gender mainstreaming. When it comes to gender issues, when we mention gender, people think that we are talking about the female gender but that is not the issue. We are the same, and we should work hand-in-hand, and that at this point, we are expecting the male gender to support the female, to build our capacity, build our composure, build our system in such a way that when we want to do something, we do not have a problem.

Mr Speaker, there are legislative gaps. For instance, we have the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024, but it is not operationalised because we do not have the needed Legislative Instrument and I think we should work hand-in-hand with the Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection to make sure that we bring the Legislative Instrument to make the Affirmative Action Act operational.

Again, we need to create that conscious awareness, that what men can do, women can do better. It has been in the system; it has been a talk show, but as to whether we are doing it — we cannot say at the end of the day that, “what men can do, women can do better” is actually in operation. Because just now, our sister mentioned that the female team is at camp to play. How many of the men have gone to visit them to say that

“*Ayekoo*, you are doing better?” Please encourage women to do better. There is also another gap, inter-ministerial connection between the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection and other Ministries. I think the Ministers should work collaboratively to make sure that the gender policies that we are going to put out in this country will support the female gender to thrive well in society. So, what do we need to do?

Mr Speaker, we need to address these policies and put efforts or conscious measures to support the female gender to do what we are supposed to do in society. Again, there is also misinformation and disinformation. When there is a cartoon about a woman who is not well-dressed, everybody wants to look at it. When there is something about the woman, everybody wants to look at it but when it comes to the male, that one is normal. Nobody talks about it; nobody wants to discuss it. We also need to look at misinformation and disinformation, which is making women want to lag behind; want to sit in their closet; they want to be at home. They do not want to come into the system for people to cartoon them or people to say things that are not good for them to listen to.

Mr Speaker, before I sit, I want us all to understand that when we talk about gender equality, we are not saying that we want to be equal. We just want space as part of society. We want space on the table but not to push the men away. So, their actions should be tailored towards a situation where they just shift small on

the table and we sit. We are not coming to push them away. In this part of our world, let us understand that women are supporting men and we need that 30 per cent in all the organisations to help them to do their work and do it better.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for giving me the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Hon Minister. Yes, Hon Member for Kwadaso, Prof. Nyarko.

Prof Kingsley Nyarko (NPP — Kwadaso): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to add my voice to the Statements on International Day of Parliamentarianism by the Hon Member for Ho West and Chairman of the Open Government Partnership, Hon Emmanuel Kwesi Bedzrah.

Mr Speaker, the theme for this year’s celebration is “Achieving Gender Equality, Action by Action”. I think that even though we are doing our best to encourage and also to ensure that we get most of our women in government positions or to get them into mainstream politics, and other sensitive positions in society, we can do more about that. Looking at our current male to female ratio, we are talking about 14.6 per cent which is even lesser than what we recorded during the 8th Parliament. It is worrying, but I also think that as we are progressing or making progress in society, we should have intentional policies and programmes that will encourage our females in this society to appreciate and put themselves a bit more

forward, to occupy positions within our governance framework. As we speak, aside the legislature, the numbers are discouraging when we go to other sectors of our society, but I believe that more can be done about that.

Mr Speaker, beyond that, Parliament occupies a very unique, critical and central position in our democracy. Without Parliament, democracy does not stand and if we have a weak Parliament, it means that we have a very fragile democracy. That is why it behoves on us all to ensure that we do our best to strengthen our legislature, to strengthen our Parliament. If we are able to do that in terms of effective oversight, promoting transparency, accountability, inclusivity, and above all, exhibiting the highest forms of tolerance, I believe that we will be able to make huge strides.

Mr Speaker, democracy without tolerance will not get us nowhere. Because as individuals, we have divergent opinions and views, and we must respect that. I should be able to respect the divergent opinions and views from my Colleagues on the other Side. No matter how I disagree with them, I must respect them. I can only counter with superior argument. That is what we have to do. Otherwise, we find ourselves in a position that will be discomfoting. When something happens to our democracy, the first institution that will fall is Parliament. It also means that as Members of Parliament, we must exhibit the highest standards of behaviour. Society must see us to be credible, persons of integrity and persons that they can trust. Dishonesty must not be part of

us as Members of Parliament, because the moment it happens, society will look at us and they cannot trust us. That is wrong.

6.02p.m.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by commending the Chairperson of the OGP caucus, Hon Bedzrah; he has worked so hard. When it comes to helping our democracy through Parliament, Hon Bedzrah has done well and I must use this platform to commend him. But I believe that he can do more. As humans, we are not complete; we are not perfect; we can make mistakes. I also believe that we must always, at all material times, look at the strength in others. As for weaknesses, we all have them. We need to overlook people's weaknesses and help them to improve on them, but we must rely on their strength. We must encourage them on their strength. That is how we can be better in society.

Mr Speaker, on that score, I want to wish us the very best, and I am hoping that all of us here will be able to make our Parliament a meaningful one and our democracy a more enduring one that will live from generation to generation. Mr Speaker, over 30 years of parliamentary democracy in Africa is no joke. It is a huge achievement, but we must do our best to safeguard it. We must do our best to protect it. We should not go back into the First, Second or Third Republican era. We must continue on this path and make it better. That will make this country the envy of the world.

Thank you very much for the opportunity, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, can I come to Leadership?

Mr Dafeamekpor — *rose* —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I said I will only accept your proposition based on the mood of the House.

Anyway, let me invite the Hon Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection.

Minister for Gender, Children and Social Protection (Dr Agnes Naa Momo Lartey) (MP): I want to thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by the Chairman of the OGP of Ghana's Parliament.

Today, as we speak, with the OGP, Ghana's Parliament goes a step higher in terms of scoring positive marks. The theme, as the OGP Chairman has stated, “Enhancing gender equality action by action”, is very critical for us, especially with the passage of the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Bill, 2024, so that with our collective efforts, we will walk the path towards gender equality. The most critical thing for us to look at this moment is not just the little efforts that we are putting in, but how to sustain those efforts so that it is not as if we take three steps forward and then two steps backwards. Today, when we look at the number of women in Parliament as

against the number of men, we would realise that we still have a long way to go, so this is an awakening call for all of us to come together.

The OGP promotes transparency and accountability. It is one of the tenets we need in order to promote gender equality. So, all of us need to commit to it, so that we will be able to sustain the efforts that we are making. It is also important for us to take note that in the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024, which was passed by this House last year— this month will be one year— When we look at the Act, especially for elected leadership positions, there are certain critical steps that we need to take. And with these steps, if we lose sight of the timelines, it will be difficult for us to measure ourselves to say that next year, 2026, we will be able to achieve 30 per cent. We have to make the conscious effort to take note of the calendars of the political parties and where to come in to ensure that we harmonise the efforts that are being made or the calendar activities of the political parties, so that we do not miss the opportunity to add more women onto the elected positions. Not just more women—I want to reiterate the fact that we need more women at critical positions where decisions are taken.

I also want to say that we need to also sustain this thing by reminding ourselves of the various responsibilities that we owe to this House and the nation at large. So, when we talk about gender equality, we need to all see to it that it is devoid of partisan colouration in order for us to unite against anything that brings inequality in terms of the gender gaps

being widened. Today, as we celebrate our efforts so far, I want to encourage us to keep the momentum and for us all to unite against inequality. We must also put in efforts to bridge the gender gap.

Let me once again say that I thank the maker of this Statement.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. I can now comfortably come to Leadership.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I think it would be fair if we have one of our Colleagues—Mr Speaker, after taking one from the Majority Side, it would be fair we have one of our Colleagues who also wants to have a bite before you come to Leadership.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Member for Effia?

Mr Isaac Nyarko-Boamah: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, before I comment on the Statement, the Leader of Government Business moved a Motion and you asked that it should be distributed to Members; that is the Financing Agreement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We have not moved a Motion. We laid a Paper.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Yes, the Paper that was laid. I am guided. But you asked that the Paper be distributed to Members.

I just want to let you know that we have still not received any Papers yet.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Chairman of Finance Committee?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I thought we were commenting on the Statement. So, if my Colleague here is raising any other issue, let us conclude on the Statement because we supported the laying of the Paper. So, we can conclude on the Statement. I thought he wanted a bite on the Statement.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP—Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, I would like to comment on the Statement ably presented by my Colleague on the other Side. Mr Speaker, it is just a matter of fact that the issues around gender equality or equity are very critical for nation building. The steps we are going to take to bridge the gender gap have been a topic on many political talk shows. So, it is not surprising that the Government of the day made some lofty—

Mr Dafeamekpor — rose —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon, I have given him the floor.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, it is just a guide. The Hon Member should advert his mind to the Statements in question and then he can

address them. The comments cannot be at large; it must be in context. So, Mr Speaker, the Hon Member must be guided in respect of his comments.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Do you know something? Today, I want the House to be very conducive. So, I do not want any— So, my Brother—

6.12 p.m.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, he is warming up into the Statement.

So, he should be allowed to—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, but, of course, be guided.

Mr Boamah-Nyarko: Of course, I am guided, but I saw the Majority Chief Whip indicating that we need to close this session and go to another. So, Mr Speaker, I will permit the House to continue with the next steps and then we will take it from there.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Worlanyo Tsekpo, have you finished? Very well, thank you.

Now, let me come to Leadership.

Deputy Minority Leader (Ms Patricia Appiagyei): Thank you, Mr Speaker and I want to thank the maker of the Statement, Hon Bedzrah, for taking us through the critical need of ensuring that we achieve gender equity, action-by-action.

Mr Speaker, I cannot agree more with my Hon Lamisi Akanvariba on the fact that, in order to achieve gender equity, we need to identify the critical factors that affect the achievement of this gender equity and it is important. When we say action-by-action, it means that we cannot just overlook anything that is contributing to the challenge of achieving that kind of equity. So, it is important that the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection, which is the oversight Ministry ensuring the implementation of the affirmative action plan, has a critical responsibility to ensure that whatever has to be done to facilitate the implementation of the Affirmative Action Act, 2024 is done at a more facilitated mode than it is doing at the moment. I know that the Minister got up and indicated a number of steps that has to be taken, but I feel that it is her responsibility to ensure that. This is because we have a right roadmap of pursuing and ensuring that we will do so.

When we say action-by-action, it means that in selecting appointees for a government responsibility, we need to ensure that we achieve 30 per cent in every aspect of appointments that is made by the Government. It is also important that we establish the systems or various mechanisms that we would use to assess the achievement of that 30 per cent. It also means that we need to make a conscious effort.

The reason we require a number of women in Parliament, or trying to achieve gender equity or equality, is to ensure that we cannot overlook the responsibility of Parliament in ensuring

that, if we cannot make sure that we achieve our constitutional mandate, we should not overlook our engagement with the civil society, queen mothers and with all strata of people that we need to engage.

Mr Speaker, I would like to even mention that, as we speak now, even as Women's Caucus of this Parliament, because of our numbers, when we want to ensure the implementation of the Affirmative Action Act, 2025 is done so appropriately, what we have adopted to do is to even engage our queen mothers because our numbers are few to ensure its implementation. So, it is important that whatever action must be taken to ensure gender equity must be done with the supervision of the right sector Ministry to achieve that.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you for my contribution.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Majority Leadership?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on. The Hon Minority Leader has indicated to me that he will comment on it.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker, that is why I want to plead with you to take a senior Member of this House, who is also active in this matter, Hajia Laadi Ayamba, to also comment; then Leadership can conclude.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Member for Pusiga.

Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba (NDC — Pusiga): Thank you, Mr Speaker, and I thank the Hon Leader for the opportunity. Let me thank the maker of the Statement, Hon Bedzrah, for the Statement that has been made. We are grateful.

Mr Speaker, I believe that the theme which he has put across could not have come at a better time. Fortunately, on our part, this Parliament passed the Affirmative Action Act, 2024 (Act 1121). The issue of equity has become law and, once it has become law since 2024, what we need next is action to ensure that it is implemented. Once there is equity, I believe that, gradually, we will be able to get the equality that we are looking at.

Mr Speaker, there is a lot of action that needs to be taken to enable us to implement the Affirmative Action Act, 2024. Mr Speaker, in this very Chamber, we will understand and know that this is a law. But how many people out there — even those who are supposed to support us, let us even start from the Unit Committee level, where leadership in politics starts — are ready to support us? And how many people understand, even at the district assemblies, that this law that has been passed needs to be adhered to? We need to work, go out there and do the sensitisation.

In my assembly, there is not even one woman who has been elected in the assembly elections. This is because that

understanding is not there and people think that leadership, many a time, is about men. We are not, in any way, interested in taking the lead and leaving men behind. I have consciously, Mr Speaker, always said when we speak about gender, we are not speaking about only women. We want us to understand that both men and women should be supported to rise to the leadership levels that we need.

Mr Speaker, in this direction, I wish to plead that, in order for laws that we pass in this House to not stay on the table, let us all, as Members of Parliament, bring our hands on deck and support the implementation of the Affirmative Action (Gender Equity) Act, 2024. Many a time, we mix the two and people do not even get where we want them to get. Mr Speaker, once we have a level playing field, I believe that there are many more women out there who can work their way up if given the opportunity. But where would the support come from if we do not do the sensitisation, even with colleague women? Because for today, we know that we have a higher number than the men.

We may go to a voting centre and out of the 200 people we would find there, there might be 130 women. But if a woman is contesting, Mr Speaker, at the end of the day, you might find that 170 have voted for the man and only 30 have voted for the woman. The question arises

and I want us to correct this and then to continue to talk to women.

6.22 p.m.

Mr Speaker, many a times, some of us, women, go on to say that we are not our own enemies, but come to think of it, we need a lot of education to let us understand that we need one another.

Mr Speaker, apart from that, governments, whether the NDC or NPP Governments or whichever government comes to play, should take up this and consider the fact that we need that support.

Mr Speaker, just the Eighth Parliament, we had 20 women each on both Sides and we were 40. Come to think of it, before we could say jack, at the 2024 election, we lost so seriously that left only 10 women of our Sisters at the other Side and we also lost some women on our Side, although we increased to 30. But if they had the 20 women and we also had the 30, we would have been 50. Let us ask ourselves, what happened?

Mr Speaker, I want to plead that you support us. I have always said it. A woman is never your enemy. If one has no sister or aunt, please, they have a mother and we need that support. But then, let me also caution that we should not rely on only the women and the girl child and forget about the boy child. Let me also give this caution because as we forge ahead, if we are not careful, we might also miss out on the boy child and eventually, the men. That will be a very big problem for us.

Mr Speaker, I say this because I have seen in certain spaces, especially social media, that men are compelled to marry more than one because women outnumber the men. Mr Speaker, while we fight for this and work hard to ensure that we are projected and supported to get to the leadership roles, we should not forget about the boy child.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to urge my Colleagues here to support us and to give out the information out there to let our assemblies and regions or wherever we are found know that there is a law that we should be given equal opportunities to enable us to participate politically. Any leadership role, we should be given that opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I thank you.

Let me now come to the Minority Leader. It is all right; no comments?

Yes, Majority Leader? Very well.

Hon Members, do we take another Statement? I have another Statement to take. So, if the Reports are not ready, then I can take the Statement.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, yes, we should take the one that stands in

the name of the Hon Ida Asiedu, Member of Parliament for Ayesuano.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me call the Hon Member for Ayesuano Constituency, Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu, to make a Statement on sand winning.

Yes, Hon Member, you have the floor now.

The Prevalence of Sand Winning Activities in Ghana: A Call for Urgent Action

Ms Ida Adjoa Asiedu (NPP — Ayensuano): Mr Speaker, I am most grateful for the opportunity given me to deliver a Statement on the floor of this august House on dangers posed by sand winning in Ghana.

Mr Speaker, sand winning, also known as sand mining, involves the extraction of sand from the earth for construction and other purposes. This activity, which is often carried out in river channels, flood plains, along the slopes of highlands and on coastlands, produces sand used as raw material for construction of roads, bridges, houses, factories, schools, markets, offices and glassware.

Mr Speaker, sand is arguably the most mined substance worldwide due to its extensive use in the construction industry. According to the United Nations Environment Programme (UNEP), about 50 billion tonnes of sand is extracted from lakes, riverbeds, coastlines and deltas each year.

Mr Speaker, the versatility of sand and the rapidly increased human population have occasioned an upsurge in demands for construction-grade sand, leading to the multiplicity of players, including illegal ones, becoming engaged in the sand mining industry.

Mr Speaker, in Ghana, sand winning is regulated by law. The Minerals and Mining Act, 2006 (Act 703) provides the legal framework for sand mining. Miners are to procure licences to legalise their operations. However, it is a known fact that many sand miners use unapproved means to extract material in a way that threatens the sustainability of the product and the environment from which it is extracted. Sand winning activities are scattered across the length and breadth of the country, from the coast to our northern borders. Special mention should be made of the Ayensuano Constituency where sand winning activities are causing serious havoc to many farmlands, and many places such as Coaltar, Kraboa, Otuase, Anfaso, Asuboi, Aye Kukuso, and many more areas.

Sand winning activities have rendered most farmland infertile for crop cultivation in the Ayensuano district. The land cover is destroyed, rendering the land prone to erosion and degradation. In some cases, it has also left the ground pocked with open pits, which are filled up in rainy seasons, providing breeding ponds for disease-carrying mosquitoes.

Mr Speaker, in other parts of the country, the effect is seen in biodiversity

laws, reduction in both agricultural and coastal lands, lowering of the water table and pollution. There is also an increase in land conflicts occasioned by the inadequate compensation of land acquired from communities and individuals for sand winning purposes. Sand winning, again, poses an existential threat to livelihood through, among other things, water supply, food production, fisheries and the tourism industry.

Mr Speaker, research has identified unemployment, population pressure, and difficulties in the acquisition of sand for building and construction as some of the causes of sand winning in Ghana. Other causes include ineffective law enforcement, poor coastal surveillance and systemic corruption.

Mr Speaker, urgent action is needed to avoid a sand crisis in the foreseeable future. The various Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies and the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) must ensure the rigorous enforcement of mining laws, implement intervention for decent alternative livelihoods and fight systemic corruption while educating the public on the negative impact of the practice on environmental, social and economic sustainability. As a country, we may also learn from other countries like China and the United States of America (USA) who have already begun producing crushed rock as an alternative to sand mining. We should encourage investments into this new area of sand production.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, on 17th January, 2025, residents of Krabo in the

Ayensuano Constituency witnessed a rather unfortunate incident where sand miners, accompanied by land guards, unleashed violence against farmers and landowners who were peacefully protesting the seizure and destruction of their farmlands.

6.32 p.m.

This sad incident led to the killing of two persons with several others injured.

Mr Speaker, our failure to urgently address the menace of sand winning may render the country incapable of handling extreme events such as drought, floods and storm surges. This would also hinder our collective effort towards achieving Goal 13 of the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals on Climate Action. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me first and foremost identify my Brother there.

Dr Ebenezer Prince Arhin (NDC—Mfantseman): Thank you Mr Speaker for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by my dear sister regarding sand winning. This subject is really important to the extent that my constituency has suffered the damage of this sand winning. Yes, we know population has outgrown some of our developmental projects and thereby causing unemployment in the country. So, some youth resort to this kind of business for construction. But the area that really touches the soul of this country is that sand winning is

sometimes geared towards *galamsey* river bodies.

Mr Speaker, if you come to Mfantseman Constituency where we depend solely on the Ochi River and because of *galamsey* activities, people try to mine sand from the river lines thereby creating a lot of potholes; big or gargantuan potholes. So, before the rain falls and water comes to where we gather and treat water in Mfantseman, it has to fill all the potholes before we gather them. A couple of months ago, it would interest this House to know that for almost two weeks, I was buying water worth GHC2,000 per truck just to make sure I provide enough water for hospitals and schools because of *galamsey* activities. Sand winning is not only done to construct blocks. We have sand miners that will try and divert the river bodies where the flow of water is causing a lot of havoc to our riverfront.

Mr Speaker, I want to send an invitation to agencies like Environmental Protection Agency to look at the aspect of controlling those who fetch sand from our riverfront. I also call on all of us here to look at our behaviours. Looking at making profit out of sand winning is going to cause a lot of trouble for our future. Recently, we had children going to fetch water by our river body, but because of this dug-out pit, our innocent children who were just fetching water fell into the pit and valuable souls were lost.

Mr Speaker, I am calling on those of us here as Members of Parliament to come together and support this dream of

the 24-Hour Economy. It is the only way we can redirect the attention of these youth to rather go back to the classroom and get valuable jobs to do. I am happy that in the recent allocation of the District Assemblies Common Fund, a lot of funds have been allocated towards construction of schools and it will pull our kids from mining sand in the riverfront into the classrooms.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I am calling on all the agencies and the regulatory bodies in the country that if we are serious about protecting the future of our river bodies, we should look at bringing the youth back to the classrooms and also encouraging them to stay in class, and going very hard on those who are encouraging these illegal activities in the country. With these few words, I appreciate the opportunity to contribute to this Statement ably made by my sister. Thank you. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Let me give the opportunity to the Hon Member for Bimbilla.

Mr Dominic Bingab Aduna Nitiwul (NPP— Bimbilla): Thank you, Mr Speaker. First of all, let me congratulate my Colleague for making this very important Statement. When I heard her speak, the type of impeccable English she spoke, her voice and control over the English language — She was reading and I could see that when there was a need for high pitch, she would do it. — [*Hear! Hear!*]—When there was a need for low pitch, she would do it. Mr Speaker, not just that, her composure

was exemplary. Mr Speaker, the content itself was so rich and appetising that I was wondering if she was a first-timer? I was imagining that this is a fifth-timer. [**Some Hon Members:** Eii] So in my head, I was tempted to tell Mr Speaker to give her a standing ovation.

Mr Speaker, the topic she chose is very important. If I have somebody from the other Side who does a similar thing, I will give the same accolade. Just deliver a similar Statement and I will say the same thing. I had the occasion to as the Minister for Defence then to come and speak on sand winning when the military had to go and burn some tipper trucks and excavators in some part of the country where I would not want mention. It is an activity that if we do not regulate, in the next five years, it will be the same thing as *galamsey*. The reason is that all of us need to build houses and we need sand to build houses. But the difficulty is that we have just not regulated it and allowed it to be anybody's game. So, somebody finds sand somewhere, it does not matter whether it is by the river, the stream or a water body, they just go and put excavator there and pollute the water and take the sand. There is no regulation; there is nothing. They just see the rural chief or the area chief and they are good to go.

But Mr Speaker, it is as dangerous and serious in water pollution as *galamsey*. It is unfortunate that in many places, it is difficult to get good drinking water unless water is taken from the soil. And there are some places where you can dig a borehole and not get water. Can you

imagine people have to walk tens of kilometres to just get drinking water to drink? In many places, because it is regulated, sand winning is actually used to desilt rivers and clean the rivers up. So, if we regulate it properly, Mr Speaker, we will not have the situation we have in the *galamsey* fields. But if we do not regulate it, we are going to end up like what has happened with *galamsey*, where it has become very lucrative and people are making a lot of money and it is difficult to stop.

So, I want to congratulate the maker of the Statement for the fact that she has realised the good sides and the dangers of sand winning. There are good and bad things with sand winning. Let us tackle the bad part of sand winning and encourage and improve the good aspects of sand winning. As I have said, it is good because people need houses. But the question is, are we going to continue, especially in urban areas, to use it for block and mortar as we continue to do?
6.42 p.m.

There are many places today that buildings are composed of only about 5 per cent of block and mortar because people are using steel to build. Within two months, they are able to build houses that can stand the test of time for hundreds of years.

But today, we are still building 30-storey buildings, 40-storey buildings, 50 floors with block and mortar and so we need a lot of sand. But in many places, all these skyscrapers you see, all these undulating buildings, all these buildings

that have all the stiles, folding and burning, it is still very high-quality steel that they use. You are not going to have a situation, Mr Speaker, where you are going to use block to build from head to toe; it is difficult. But unfortunately, that is what we have. If you show a structure to somebody and say, look, “I want to build it with steel”, Ghanaians do not like it. But I think that the regulators, the Government, that is supposed to provide the policies, must begin to see what we can do to reduce the use of sand winning.

Mr Speaker, the Northern Development Authority in those days also introduced this new brick system where they used local materials, the gravels, and were producing blocks that were even stronger than those made from sand. Mr Speaker, the bricks that did not use sand, were even stronger than those made from sand. I think that is another area we should look at it, so that we could stop exploiting this sand, especially those around the river areas.

I would say that areas such as water treatment plants should have a policy of some two or three kilometres of a no-go area for such areas, so that at least, people can get good drinking water to drink. If we do not have a policy like that we are going to have a problem. So, I would suggest that, yes, it is good to win sand, but we should win sand with regulations; we should win sand with policy. We should win sand in a very responsible manner. If we do not do that, Mr Speaker, we are going to have a

situation and the problems that we are currently having in the *galamsey* fields.

Mr Speaker, Ghana used to have a huge forest reserve. We have virtually finished everything and if it is not raining, people do not understand why it is not raining. People do not appreciate that rain is linked to the forest cover you have and also the sea that you have. It is all linked together because those trees will have to produce carbon monoxide.

Mr Speaker, I have been told that there are many admirers of our lady who made the Statement. Not admirers in trying to woo her, but admirers in the way she made the Statement and they want to contribute to the Statement. So, Mr Speaker, I will not want to take too much time because the Statement is just for one hour. I will end here by congratulating my Colleague from Ayensuano and telling the people of Ayensuano that they have a very good Member of Parliament (MP). I want them to know that they have given us a good material; a very quality material. What I heard, I want her to speak more because if a first timer can speak like this, if a first timer can be composed like this, if a first timer can put this type of Statement together and stand up and read the way she did, and speak the way she spoke, I tell you, the sky can only be her limit and I pray that she stays here for about four or five times like me

—[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Speaker, she stays here about four or five times like me to blow herself up because she is a very good material. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

[Hear! Hear!]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. I will take one more from each Side. Now we are talking about sand winning. The Deputy Minister for Lands and Natural Resources.

Alhaji Yusif Sulemana (NDC — Bole Bamboi): Mr Speaker, I do not intend to talk too much on this subject matter but I want to thank the maker of the Statement for bringing up this very important issue for discussion.

Mr Speaker, we are talking about the extraction of sand in its natural state for the purposes of building and construction.

Mr Speaker, human activities account for some of these destructions of our environment. Mr Speaker, it is not only the winning of the sand, but even before you win the sand, you have to clear the vegetation, you have to fall some trees and that is also a destruction in itself. Normally this takes place around the inland areas, around riverbeds, and around beaches. It also tells you that it has its effects even when it comes to tourism because beaches where we are supposed to beautify, to attract people to come and pay something to us, are all being depleted because of sand winning and it is also a very serious issue that we have to look at.

Mr Speaker, my senior Colleague who has just spoken made a passionate call for some policies, regulations and a legislation, if possible, to be made but even before we get there, I would want to

appeal to the Local Government structures, the Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs), the District Assemblies, they can start with byelaws to ensure that people who go about exploiting and mining sand in a manner that does not help us are all checked and so that is where I want to start it from.

My Minister, a couple of days ago, also received some concerns about this sand winning and he is putting together a team to look at it so that we can come out with the appropriate laws and policies to be able to reduce the impact of sand winning and so once again, let me thank the maker of the Statement and to assure her that it is already on the table for discussion and that at appropriate time, we will invite her and invite those who have interest in this subject matter so that we are able to put together some policy guidelines to guide us in this direction.

Let me encourage her that it is not only about reading Statements that will keep her here for the number of years that they are proposing. You need to do more than that and to do more than that means that you must be able to distinguish between what is politics and what is not politics when it comes to the work of this Parliament. For instance, when we are passing a legislation, when we are passing a law, you should not just listen to your Side and go with them when you do not believe in what they are asking you to do. Thank you. *[Laughter.]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Members, I am now turning to Leadership.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I heard my Colleagues on both Sides commending our good Friend and Member from Ayensuano, a proud easterner. But what they failed to observe is that, Mr Speaker, you admitted the Statement at the very last hour by your benevolence. You admitted the Statement and they failed to acknowledge that.

Mr Speaker, let me commend you highly for admitting the Statement. Had it not been your action, we would not have witnessed this spirited and beautiful delivery by the Member.

Again, Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister for Land and Natural Resources, well, maybe, I will stay clear. He is my friend. He was inviting me to other matters, Mr Speaker, this matter had come up before. I think during the Eighth Parliament, we had the opportunity to consider the same subject matter, sand winning.

Ultimately, Parliament constituted an *ad hoc* Committee which I was privileged to Chair. We have travelled the length and breadth of this country and came out with a Report.

6.52 p.m.

So it was very surprising that sand winning was even taking place in the Volta Lake. The Volta Lake had been subjected to sand-winning activities in the Eastern Region and other farming communities. Sand winning was being engaged in irresponsibly.

I heard my senior Colleague, Hon Nitiwul, say that it is not being regulated. We have all the regulatory legal regimes. We have the Minerals Commission, the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA), and the MMDCEs who are empowered to regulate these activities. The enforcement of the existing regulation is a challenge. And the coordination between the EPA, the Minerals Commission, and the MMDCE has been the concern of the day. I hope we can deal with these matters.

The EPA does not have branches all over the country because of the resource limitations they are confronted with. So the challenge cannot be left at the doorstep of the EPA alone because they do not have the wherewithal in terms of resources to be able to prosecute on these requirements. There should be coordinated activities between the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, the EPA, the Minerals Commission, and the Ministry for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs because the MMDCEs come in the wake.

Mr Speaker, we have lamented enough about this challenge. I think it is time we take action as a House. And, Mr Speaker, you have said that you are not too enthused about consequential directives. I would have suggested that we take some action on these matters because of the attendant effect of food security. They are scooping away arable lands in droves. Sand winning is taking place within water bodies. And the food security concerns cannot just be wished away.

Amidst all the legal regimes, this is happening in droves. And it is high time we pulled the brakes. The EPA, as I said, cannot do it all by itself. I wish Parliament could have a role, and the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs and other relevant Committees could come in to follow up on this matter to its logical conclusion.

A beautiful Statement read in a very beautiful way by a beautiful Member of Parliament. [*Hear! Hear!*] I did some rhyming back at secondary school, Bishop Herman College. A beautiful Statement delivered by a beautiful Member of Parliament for a constituency called Ayensuano Constituency, which is a beautiful constituency in a very beautiful region, the Eastern Region.

Mr Speaker, I pray your consequential directives on this matter. The Leader of the House has given a certain twist to all the outstanding matters which should be dealt with. We cannot leave this matter to die naturally. The conversation should go on and on until it is dealt with.

Mr Speaker, apparently, I share a border with the Member of Parliament. And the respected Minority Leader has a special interest in that Constituency. Osahen Afenyo-Markin has volunteered that he will be making a special visit to that Constituency. And we will be joined by the Majority Leader, who has been given unfettered access to our Side. [*Interruption*] —How? I am speaking in parables.

So we will commend the Member who has delivered a very good Statement.

And I hope that this matter can be continued to its logical conclusion.

I thank you for indulging me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Majority Leadership.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I have seen the Chief Whip of the Majority Bench standing at the back. What he is doing is that he is whipping his Members. There are no surprises. Whatever they want to do, we will support them to do it. So, he should not be too busy. He should stop sweating. He is standing there. He is afraid of his own shadow. He is in his *bubu*, whipping his Members to come in around this time. We have seen the Ministers coming in. The Minister for Education has already come. We will see the rest. He is busy calling them to come. They want to populate this place.

But let them come and we would now question them. They said they would not take a loan, and now, they are taking a loan. Mr Speaker, please judge by the way.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I was going to ask you to—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, very well.

Mr Speaker, this is another moment for me to say a few words to encourage our first-timers. We have a Parliament with very determined first-timers. I am

happy that they are demonstrating courage to make their name for the records. I listened, and I said, is she really a first-timer?

Mr Speaker, our Friends opposite me recall that when we were considering the Budget, one of them, I do not remember his constituency—I praised him. He was not from our Side. I was watching him from my office, and I rushed into the Chamber to take a close look. Although he was just punching my party, it was not about what he was saying against my party, but the content of his submission, his ability to deliver.

And today, we are seeing a great talent right in my backyard. Already, I have great talents. The Hon Member for Nalerigu/Gambaga; he is doing great. I have my own Walewale champion. Mr Speaker, behind me, I can see the Hon Member for Suhum. I can see Hon John Darko. That great man, Hon Asafo-Adjei, is right behind me over there. Mr Speaker, and I am seeing Hon Fatahiya Abdul Aziz, Lawyer Mmieh and Hon Damata Salam. These are great talents and it adds up to the promise for the future of Parliament.

Mr Speaker, these talents are not only limited to my Side, but I can see many more on the other Side as well. Mr Speaker, all I will say to them is, they should be inspired by their own dream, and make their name in Parliament. For those who have taken it upon themselves to always heckle and shout, especially on the other Side, they should learn. They have to learn from the industry of our lady from Ayensuano. She really

struggled to win her seat. She worked so hard. I think today, she has made herself proud. She has made the constituents who voted for her proud.

7.02 p.m.

I do not want to touch on even the subject matter. The industry is worth emulating.

Mr Speaker, but let me use this opportunity to make a strong case for us to revisit our Standing Orders. The provision at Order 119 that talks about Members only referring to their notes and not to read is something we need to revisit because, in all advanced democracies, Members are required to research, prepare, and come into the Chamber and deliver from their scripts. With his *extempore*, sometimes one looks into the *Hansard* and realises that their thoughts are so entangled and all.

Mr Speaker, I pray that, going forward, apart from Statements, Members will be encouraged to prepare and debate from their written Statements, so that *Hansard* can capture their industry and capture it well, especially for the young ones. Mr Speaker, it is not all of us who can speak from our thoughts and still regulate same. Sometimes, we are concerned that this is keeping many people away from speaking on the Floor.

Mr Speaker, the Rule I was referring to is Order 119, subtitled, Reading of Speech by Member and it provides:

“A Member shall not read the Member’s speech, to the largest extent possible, but may read extracts from written, printed or electronic document in support of the Member’s submission or may refresh the Member’s memory by reference to note.”

Mr Speaker, this provision, with the greatest respect, must be looked at and I suggest strongly that when Speakers are presiding, they relax this provision. Because if we watch debates in the U.S. Senate or British Parliament, no member speaks *extempore*. They come with their written submission for full debate. So why it is that, as a growing democracy like ours, Members come and we say they should not read their speech. We should only refer to their notes.

Mr Speaker, I have taken it upon myself to be reading my debates going forward. I will rely on my written text. I will not depart from it and I will seek your leave. I would not do it as of right anyway; I will seek your leave and I know leave will be granted.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, I shall join my respected Colleague, Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh, he was my senior at University of Cape Coast, a student leader and he is very hard working. I know he is a survivor and he is of that stock that deals with environmental issues, though he started in the agro sector. But he has made a very profound call.

That profound call is to the effect that this Statement be transmitted to the Minister for the sector to look at it. The last time we had a Committee to look at this sand winning—There is a problem in my own Constituency. If we go to the rural areas: Gyahadze, Gyengyenadze and Ateitu, people have lost their farmlands as a result of these sand winning activities. It has to be regulated and we should confine them to certain areas. They are just doing it anyhow and, like the maker of the Statement said, they see community leaders give them some *noko fio* and they destroy the environment.

I do not know whether it is the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology who will be responsible for this. If so, I believe that Dr Murtala Muhammed Ibrahim will receive this Statement and take a serious action on this matter, so that serious action is taken. What is happening to our environment? We come here and take this for granted; *galamsey* is already killing us and sand winning is also problem. The time has come for us, as a nation, to rally around certain issues and make them national issues and say that this is about the country and not National Democratic Congress (NDC) or New Patriotic Party (NPP).

Like what happened this morning and this afternoon, a day of National Thanksgiving, it is a national call. Can we, as a Government, proactively take steps to enact or pronounce certain canker in society and make it a national issue that will rally all political actors around it without being hypocritical in

terms of the approach? I am sure if we do that, our democracy will last for all of us.

Mr Speaker, the West Africa sub-region is suffering because they allow some of these things to eat deep into society to a boiling point. Ghana is a safe haven. Many people come here not because we have achieved something by accident but because we made a conscious effort. But we can do better as a country. As political actors, we can do better because some of the dangers that we see, if we do not take steps to stop them, none of us will survive when that day comes. I repeat: none of us, the political actors, will survive when that day comes. So, please, let us forget about the temporal pleasures of power and look at Ghana in the beyond: Ghana 20 or 30 years from today. The best way to enjoy our peace is to have democracy with strengthened pillars as well.

Mr Speaker, without more, I shall thank you for indulging me—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you so much.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I am not done. I am thanking you, so let me finish.

Mr Speaker, without more, let me thank you for indulging me and also commend you for admitting this Statement and, at least, helping our Colleague have her first major bite, which without doubt, has been very

commendable and outstanding by all standards.

Mr Speaker, I take my bow.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Majority Leadership?

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, this is just to commend the maker of the Statement for a thought-provoking Statement on a matter that might be overlooked by many, but which, if not attended to, could have devastating environmental consequences for all of us.

Mr Speaker, I agree that sand winning is a matter that we need to pay attention to, except to say that there are clear regulations governing how to acquire licence for sand winning where sand can be mined, and the measures that can be taken to address the fallout in terms of the environmental consequences.

So long as we want to build homes and we will use sand, there will be sand winning. So, it is a question of where and how, so I will call on MMDAs because, primarily, it is their responsibility to regulate these matters and also the Small-Scale Mining Division of the Minerals Commission. They are also responsible for regulating matters of sand winning. I do not believe that it has significant environmental pollution consequences.

Mr Speaker, scooping the sand and loading it to construction sites does not in any way pollute the environment. It is not like small-scale mining. With small-

scale mining, the pollution component arises from the use of chemicals like mercury and other extractive chemicals. But in the case of sand winning, it is just a scooping of the sand and then the hauling of the sand to locations where they will be needed.

7.12 p.m.

I think the effect of erosion is what is a major issue and of course, most of it happens along the banks of rivers and the sea and those could have some consequences on settlements along the riverbanks and the coast. Those are the real dangers that relate to sand winning, but I believe that it is a matter that can easily be taken care of.

Mr Speaker, this being the first Statement she has made, let me commend her and encourage her to build confidence that will make life in this Chamber a very enjoyable one for herself as a first-timer and to encourage her to be in this House.

Mr Speaker, that is what I will say for now, given that we have very important Business before us which is contained in the Order Paper *Addendum*. Mr Speaker, the Report is now ready, so if we can have the House to take the item numbered 3, which is —*[Interruption]*— Have we already laid it? Sorry, the item numbered 2.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we will bring Statements to a close. My invitation to make referrals on Statements has always been the same. I am now hesitant in doing that because of

the numerous referrals that have been made to the Committees, but no reports have been produced for us to consider.

That notwithstanding, for this particular one, I will ask that the Table transmits this Statement to the Minister for Lands and Natural Resources as well as the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to look into it and see how best they can address the issues because it relates to local government and district assemblies where sand winning takes place. They are in charge. Then, because sand is a natural resource, the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources and the Minerals Commission are responsible for it.

I will direct that the Table transmits this particular Statement to the Ministers concerned. I so direct.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I thought we could load your directives further by adding the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology. You already mentioned the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, but the Ministry of Environment, Science and Technology because the Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) is an agency under that Ministry.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Please, Table, add the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology in the transmittal as well. I so direct.

Yes, Minority Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, earlier, the Majority Leader

made an application, which application was for us to look at an Order Paper *Addendum*. I have just seen it. The mainstay of his prayer, basically, was that we should take the Motion numbered 2 and the Deputy Whip circulated the Report of the Finance Committee which I have a copy of.

Mr Speaker, my understanding is that this Parliament is not being cajoled. The Executive, under this reset system, wants to do something new. We have the Finance Committee going into a meeting to consider a Report. If this Report is considered tomorrow, what would happen? What would happen? It is 7 p.m.— *[Interruption]*— No, I want to know. Mr Speaker, I want to know that if this is taken tomorrow, what would change?

Mr Speaker, one too many, we have seen Reports brought and we are told we should be in a hurry. Mr Speaker, if there is some urgency around it, I do not have a problem, but between now, this evening, and tomorrow afternoon that we would convene, what would be the difference? I just want to know. Especially, upon reading the Report, there is no clarity as to the purpose of the loan. There is no clarity. They only generally talked about budgetary support, but there is no clarity. The Report itself says that the Minister could not provide clarity as to the specific purpose of this facility and that it would be a general budgetary support.

Mr Speaker, I would plead with the Leader of Government Business, unless he wants to use his numbers, but if he

aims to build consensus and carry the entire House, then we should allow the laying of the Reports. Let us come tomorrow, read and deal with this. Mr Speaker, this is my very humble suggestion because if we go by the majoritarian and we have the numbers, the views of national interest will be relegated.

If we see the World Bank facility, they said the whole facility, but if we look at the Report, paragraph 6.4, it says that it is just 2 per cent all in cost — *[Interruption]*— No, please. I am not moving a Motion. I am speaking to the fact. It is 2.5, which is all right. This means that relatively, the cost is not too high, but we should have the opportunity to interrogate the issues. We cannot just lay it and say that we should take it immediately — *[Interruption]*— Yes, they have briefed me. They were, but you and I were not there. I am not talking about you as a person, but the entire Plenary. It is the Committee that has done its work and is reporting.

So, Mr Speaker, I do not want the Majority Chief Whip to be too busy. The avant-garde of Government Business should not be too busy whipping his Members to come at all cost when it is 7 p.m. and it is getting to 8 p.m. He should not whip people who are tired and are at home. He should not bring some Ministers who are working here by force because they have 183 Members to say they should populate the Chamber. Let us go home, read and come back tomorrow and make meaningful input.

Mr Speaker, I so submit. If the Majority Leader wants to say something different from what I am saying, who am I? But let us be led by the national interest. This is a reset Government that has been telling us that something new is being done — *[Interruption]*— So, will it change if we come tomorrow? If we do it tomorrow, it will change? — **[Some Hon Members of the Majority: Yes.]**—

Then say it for *Hansard*.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you.

Majority Leader, let us hear you.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader has no objection to us taking the item numbered 2 on the Order Paper *Addendum*, so let us proceed.

7.22 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, let me invite you to the item listed 2 on the Order Paper *Addendum* — Motion to be moved by the Chairman of the Committee.

MOTION

Suspension of Standing Order 104 (1)

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That notwithstanding the provisions of Order 104(1) of the

Standing Orders which requires that a Motion shall not be debated until at least two Sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the Motion is given, the Motion for the adoption of the Report of the Finance Committee on the Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing may be *moved* today.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Motion has been moved. The Vice-Chairman?

Vice-Chairman of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Mr Speaker, beg to second the motion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: This Motion, is a procedural one.

Let me hear you.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, this is a procedural Motion; I am not on my feet to debate it. But just for the records, the respected Leader of Government Business and Leader of the House, in praying for the Motion to be taken, said “the Minority Leader is not opposed to it.”. I am opposed to the Motion being taken. I am opposed to the

Motion and the records must reflect as such; that is all.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us now turn to Motion 3, the substantive Motion.

MOTIONS

Financing Agreement between the GoG and IDA of the World Bank Group for the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House adopt the Report of the Finance Committee on the Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana, (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing.

Mr Speaker, in doing so, I would like to present the Committee’s report.

Introduction

The Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing was presented to the House on Tuesday, 1st July, 2025, by the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem.

Pursuant to Article 181 of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 226(2) and 228 of the Standing Orders of the House, the Agreement was referred to the Finance Committee for consideration and report.

Deliberations

The committee was assisted by the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem and Officials from the Ministry of Finance and deliberated on the Agreement.

References

The Committee referred to the following documents during the deliberations:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- ii. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana; and
- iii. Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921).

Background of the Agreement

The significant deterioration in public finances in 2020 and 2021 led to the 2022 economic crisis, which was characterised by high inflation, rapid depreciation of the currency and high public debt burden. Government took steps to address the economic challenges, including seeking the support of International Monetary Fund (IMF) to implement a Programme to restore macroeconomic stability, debt sustainability and to support inclusive growth while protecting the poor and vulnerable.

As part of measures to provide financing assurances under the IMF Programme, in 2023, the Government of Ghana requested a US\$900 million Programmatic Development Policy Operation (DPO) series from the World Bank to be disbursed over a three-year period to support the country's recovery from the economic crisis.

The Programmatic DPO series is part of a financial assistance package from international partners to support the country's recovery efforts and set the economy on a path of strong sustainable growth.

The objectives of the DPO are to restore fiscal sustainability, support financial sector stability and private sector development, improve energy sector financial discipline and strengthen social and climate resilience. These objectives are aligned with the ongoing International Monetary Fund (IMF) Programme.

The DPO requires Government to implement an agreed set of reform actions to trigger disbursements. Following the implementation of the reform measures underpinning the first in the DPO series and with the approval of Parliament, the World Bank disbursed the first tranche of US\$300 million to Government on 27th March, 2024.

In 2024, the economy recorded stronger-than-expected growth, with annual GDP expanding by 5.7 per cent compared to 3.1 per cent in 2023. Headline inflation was 23.8 per cent in December 2024, 0.6 percentage points higher than the 23.2 per cent recorded at the end of 2023 and also exceeded the budget target of 15 percent. The Ghanaian Cedi however, witnessed a cumulative depreciation of 19.2 percent against the US dollar by the end of 2024.

In addition, there was significant fiscal slippages, with the primary balance on a commitment basis worsening from a deficit of 0.2 per cent of GDP in 2023 to a deficit of 3.9 per cent in 2024, 4.4 percentage points worse than the target surplus of 0.5 percent for the year 2024. This was on the back of significant accumulation of arrears.

The Resetting Agenda of Government focused on economic transformation, governance reforms and social development. The 2025 Budget also outlined key policies reforms and measures to restore and firmly anchor macroeconomic stability, address risks to fiscal sustainability and set the economy on a path of strong sustainable growth.

The implementation of the policies and measures in the 2025 Budget are yielding significant results, particularly on the macroeconomic front. Growth remained strong in the first quarter of the year with an overall GDP growth rate of 5.3 per cent compared to 4.9 per cent recorded in the same period in 2024. Price pressures have gradually eased in response to ongoing fiscal consolidation, appropriate tightening of monetary policy, and relative stability in the exchange rate. Headline inflation declined consecutively in the first five months of the year to 18.4 per cent in April 2025. The Cedi has appreciated strongly against major trading currencies with a year-to-date appreciation of 44.7 per cent as at 16th June, 2025. Gross International Reserves (GIR) as at end-April 2025 was US\$10.7 billion (4.7 months of imports cover), a significant improvement from the December 2024 position of US\$9.0 billion (4.0 months of import cover) and April 2024 position of US\$6.6 billion (3.0 months of import cover).

Government is keen to further deepen structural reforms to sustain macroeconomic stability and institute structures to ensure the sustainability of sound policies. In line with this objective, DPO2 will further augment Government efforts in policy overhaul in some critical areas such as public financial management, energy, financial sector, private sector investment, social protection, and climate change.

The DPO2 operation will form a critical component of our external financing strategy to support the

implementation of the 2025 Budget. Budget sets out bold and transformative fiscal measures aimed at restoring macroeconomic stability, enhancing fiscal discipline, and placing Ghana firmly back on the path to debt-to-debt sustainability. The support will be instrumental in achieving our fiscal consolidation and macroeconomic stability goals. Key areas of reform underpinning DPO2 include strengthening domestic revenue, strengthening commitment control, safeguarding financial sector stability, ensuring the financial and operational sustainability of the energy sector, strengthening the country's social protection architecture and ensuring that climate adaptation and mitigation are better mainstreamed.

In line with the Resetting Agenda, Government is seeking the release of the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing from IDA of the World Bank Group for the implementation of key policy initiatives

in the 2025 Budget to make more gains including economic stability and enhance growth.

Objective of the Facility

The objective of the request is to obtain Parliamentary approval to enable the Government of Ghana secure US\$360million Credit Facility as budgetary support to finance the implementation of some key policy initiatives in the 2025 budget under government resilient recovery development policy.

Terms and Conditions of the Agreement

The Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing is to be supported by a credit facility of US\$360 million from the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group under the following terms:

Credit Amount	US\$360,000,000.00
Repayment Period	12 years
Grace Period	6 years
Maximum Commitment Charge	0.5 – One-half of one percent (1/2 of 1%) per annum on the Unwithdrawn Financing Balance.
Service Charge	1.31% - sum of three-fourths of one percent (3/4 of 1%) per annum plus the Basis Adjustment (+56bps) to the Service Charge on the Withdrawn Credit Balance and three-fourths of one percent (3/4 of 1%) per annum, or such rate as may apply following a Currency Conversion; on the Withdrawn Credit Balance.

Interest Charge	1.25% - sum of one and a quarter percent per annum plus the Basis Adjustment to the Interest Charge (+10bps) and zero percent (0%) per annum, or such rate as may apply following a Currency Conversion; on the Withdrawn Credit Balance.
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Observations

Rationale for the Facility

It would be recalled that the House approved an amount of US\$300 million from the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for DPO1 which was to restore fiscal sustainability, support financial sector stability and private sector development; improve energy sector financial discipline, and strengthen social and climate resilience. Key areas of reform underpinning the DPO include strengthening domestic revenue mobilization, controlling expenditures, safeguarding financial sector stability, removing impediments to private investment, ensuring the financial and operational sustainability of the energy sector, strengthening the country's social protection architecture, and ensuring that climate adaptation and mitigation are better mainstreamed.

The Hon Deputy Minister informed the Committee that Ghana has made significant progress towards the attainment of a number of conditions precedent for assessing the US\$900 million facility. The Committee also noted that the government has implemented key measure to improve domestic revenue mobilisation, improve

energy sector operational and financial efficiency, promote financial sector efficiency and fostering resilience to economic and climate shocks.

Review of the Facility

The Committee observed that the entire request under the DPO series as support to the country amounted to US\$900 million. However, the Deputy Minister for Finance informed the Committee that at a meeting with the World Bank, the Facility was renegotiated and DPO2 was reviewed upward from US\$300 million to US\$360 million and then DPO3 also to be reviewed from US\$300 million to US\$400 million, bringing the total to US\$1.06 billion for DPO1, DPO2 and DPO3.

It will be recalled that in the 2025 Budget, government programmed to spend GHC13 billion owed to contractors. During the consideration of the Referral, the Committee noted that the full amount of US\$360 million from DPO2 will be used to finance part of the amount owed to the contractors. The Committee also noted that the third tranche, DPO3 yet to come on board, will also be used to finance part of the 2025 programmed arrears.

Importance of the Facility

The Committee noted that the US\$360 Million facility is not dedicated to any specific project in the 2025 Budget. The Deputy Minister of finance explained that the facility is part of General Budget Support and will be applied to finance critical aspects of the 2025 Budget. The Committee further noted that the facility constitutes IDAs budget support commitments to Ghana for the period 2023 to 2025.

All-in-Cost

The all-in-cost for the financing agreement is 2.05% per annum.

Benefits to be derived

The Committee observed that the expected outcomes of the Programme include the following:

- i. Improved revenue collection;
- ii. Improved Financial Sector Stability;
- iii. Improved Private Investment and Foreign Direct Investments;
- iv. Minimised fiscal burden caused by losses in the power sector;
- v. Improved Financial health of the power sector;

- vi. Improved power sector operational and commercial efficiency;
- vii. Improved protection for vulnerable and reduced extreme poverty;
- viii. Improved Social Safety Net and Gender Equality; and
- ix. Improved Climate Resilience.

Conclusion

The Committee having carefully examined the financing agreement for the implementation of the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Operation is of the view that facility would continue to improve livelihood of the citizens, accelerate economic growth and sustain macroeconomic stability, curb inflation and return the economy to the path of growth.

The Committee therefore recommends to the House to adopt its Report and approve the Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) for an amount of three hundred and sixty million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) in accordance with Article 181 of the Constitution and Order 226 of the Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana.

Respectfully Submitted.

Mr Speaker, the significant deterioration in public finances in 2020 and 2021 led to the 2022 economic crisis, which was characterised by high inflation, rapid depreciation of the currency and high public debt burden. Government took steps to address the economic challenges, including seeking the support of the International Monetary Fund (IMF) to implement a programme to restore macroeconomic stability, debt sustainability and to support inclusive growth while protecting the poor and the vulnerable.

As part of the measures to provide financing assurance under the IMF programme in 2023, the Government of Ghana requested a US\$900 million Programmatic Development Finance Option (DPO) series from the World Bank to be disbursed over a three-year period to support the country's recovery programme.

Mr Speaker, only last year, US\$300 million of this facility was disbursed and approved by this House. Mr Speaker, this facility is to seek the approval of the second tranche, which is US\$360 million, to assist in providing financing for the Government. Mr Speaker, the terms and conditions of the agreement, the Second Resilient Recovery Programme Development Policy Financing, is to support the credit release of about US\$360 million from the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group.

Mr Speaker, the repayment period is 12 years. There is a moratorium of six

years. The all-in costs, if we consider the cost-of-service charges and commitment charges, amounts to 2.05 per cent; that is the total cost per annum of this facility. Mr Speaker, the Government is desirous to ensure that the economic gains that we have made so far does not lead to any deterioration. As a matter of fact, the Government intends to deploy this facility to support the implementation of the 2025 Budget to achieve the project objectives of the Government.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I would like to call my Hon Colleagues, particularly my Colleagues on the other Side, who negotiated these facilities with the World Bank Group to give Ghana an amount of US\$900 million only a year ago, to now be very happy that this Government has agreed to continue with that policy. We will now require them to assist us to approve this loan so that the cedi that has now appreciated will continue to appreciate to the benefit of the people of Ghana. That the economic growth that we are experiencing will not be derailed and that the people of Ghana will see the benefit of democracy as they have always strived for.

Mr Speaker, I call on this House and all well-meaning Ghanaians to support and approve this facility for Government to quickly disburse and go ahead with its programme. Mr Speaker, I so move. Thank you very much.

Question proposed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Chairman of the Committee has moved the Motion.

Yes?

Vice-Chairman of the Committee (Mr Richard Acheampong): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise to second your Committee's Report to approve an amount of US\$360 million for the purposes of budget implementation. Mr Speaker, the House is called upon to support these very initiatives so that we can fully implement the 2025 Budget. We already approved the 2025 Budget and these are some of the indicative numbers in the Budget. So, it is like trying to make sure that whatever we said in the 2025 Budget, we are doing exactly so.

Mr Speaker, this is a very good facility and the Minority Leader agrees with us; he just mentioned it. If we check the all-in cost, it is about 2.05 per cent, which is a good deal for the country. It is not an expensive facility. Mr Speaker, the benefits to be derived from this US\$360 million, if approved by this House, would improve revenue collection, improve financial sector stability, improve private investment and foreign direct investment, minimise fiscal burden caused by losses in the power sector, improve financial health of the power sector, improve power sector operational and commercial efficiency, improve protection for the vulnerable and reduce extreme poverty, improve social safety net and gender equality, and improve climate resilience.

Mr Speaker, this is the document. We are complaining that contractors have

not been paid and Government is not spending. We cannot spend if we do not have the resources. So, these are some of the things we need to support this government with, so there will be liquidity in the system for us to fully implement the 2025 Budget approved by this House. So, I am calling on my Hon Colleagues from the other Side to fully support this approval process so that by the end of the day, there will be liquidity in the system to support the government of the day. I thank you very much for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will first and foremost turn to the Hon Member for Walewale, Hon Dr Abdul-Kabiru Tiah Mahama.

Question proposed

Dr Abdul-Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP—Walewale): Thank you very much. Mr Speaker, this House is being called upon to approve an agreement. An agreement that just some six months ago was considered unholy. An agreement that just some seven months ago was considered as the worst crime of a government then, and there was unanimity in the chorus.

7.32 p.m.

The unanimity in the chorus was to the effect that the Government was borrowing so much, and that Parliament was not going to give blessing to such a similar agreement, and it was thrown out.

Today, we are brought with a similar agreement and our part has no hesitation

whatsoever, we are putting on record that when it matters for the development of the country, we should jettison politics and pursue the national interest. This is a point that has to be made forcefully.

Mr Speaker, this agreement was negotiated as part of the financing assurance under the International Monetary Fund (IMF) programme. Mr Speaker, the IMF needed solace, they needed comfort, to the effect that when the US\$4 billion loan is given to the Republic of Ghana, other sources of funds will come in to support the Budget, because that was a budgetary support. The Government came in with several interventions, and the World Bank Development Policy Financing (DPF) was one of those interventions to give this revenue assurance.

Mr Speaker, an amount of US\$900 million was agreed to be drawn within three tranches. Mr Speaker, we are told today by the same people who said it was not good, they have increased it by US\$160 million dollars through renegotiation. Now, instead of US\$900 million, we are now going to contract US\$1.6 billion. Mr Speaker, by the same people who said that it was not good. We have to look at the sincerity of this politics we are doing. For all intent and purposes, Government having revenue assurance, Government having the ability to pay for goods and services, Government being able to prosecute the 2025 Budget is well and good and we should support. But if six months ago, you said that US\$900 million contracted to be drawn with three tranches was not good, why do you go and negotiate and

increase it by US\$160 million and asking this Parliament to approve US\$360 million of this particular tranche?

Mr Speaker, aside that, we need to note that my Hon Colleague and the Deputy Chairman for the Committee has noted the importance of fiscal stability, revenue improvement, energy sector, financial discipline, *et cetera*. This money would help us and that is the reason as a Member of the Committee and as a Member of this Side of the Minority, I am supporting this one in that regard. Mr Speaker, there is an amount of 360—It has been increased to US\$360 million, which I have noted. This hallowed Chamber will bear witness that US\$300 million was rejected, but today, US\$60 million has been added to it, and that US\$60 million is in excess of the US\$300 million that this House was trying to approve.

Mr Speaker, there is also this particular thing I would like to note, the terms of the agreement. The Chairman of the Committee presented and said that there is a moratorium of six years on this contract. Mr Speaker, that is not the details of this loan. There is a moratorium of five and six years, depending on whether we are drawing on credit B or credit A. The credit A is a short-term financing and the credit B is a long-term, which is about 25 years. That one has a six-year moratorium and the first one has a five-year moratorium and then we would start paying —

Admittedly, under the financing regime, being thrown out of the bond market and having access to the capital

market being difficult, a 2.5 per cent all building costs is something good. It is something good in terms of the financing regime. Mr Speaker, but what should be established as a matter of fact is that the debt stock of this country has been ballooned by US\$160 million by this Government, that is saying we should not borrow.

Mr Speaker, what should be established as a fact is that the Minister for Finance came to this Parliament and even before the Appointments Committee, told the Members of Parliament that we can actually develop this country without borrowing. But within six months, they cannot pay contractors and they have to borrow US\$160 million in excess of the US\$900 million that was contracted.

Mr Speaker, there is also this thing we need to note. The World Bank has approved conditionalities for this particular loan, some of which this House has not approved. Mr Speaker, the Environmental Protection Act that the Minister for Environment, Science and Technology came into this House to pass is part of the conditionalities of this particular facility. Mr Speaker, there are conditionalities regarding the Ghana Investment Promotion Centre (GIPC) law. We have not done anything about it. Mr Speaker, there are conditionalities regarding the Financial Stability Fund.

I remember in the last Parliament, Members of the other Side were against the facility because they had the feeling that the Financial Stability Fund was something that the terms and the conditions that the World Bank gave,

their participation in the Financial Stability Fund was something they did not want. Mr Speaker, under that agreement, the World Bank was expected to provide counterpart funding to support the financial sector, especially private banks, while the Government of Ghana was to provide funding to support the public banks. They were against it. Mr Speaker, that conditionality is still on the table. As to whether or not the Government will agree to that conditionality, we have not been told by the Minister for Finance, and the Report has not also captured that. We need to know whether or not this conditionality of the IMF interest in the Financial Stability Fund is something that they are agreeing to.

Mr Speaker, there is also this particular conditionality that we must note; the revenue. It means that the Government will have to also improve on revenue collection, because you cannot be borrowing on the back of your Budget. You cannot be borrowing to finance your Budget. If the Government does nothing to improve resource mobilisation, we will not be assessing them. Mr Speaker, the IMF Board has approved this Fund on condition that we will perform on the prior actions. The prior actions, some of them have not been met. We can approve it in this particular Chamber. Go out of the Chamber, the IMF will not release the money.

Mr Speaker, finally, on the use of the money, the Government says that they are using it to support Budget, but the document itself says they are using it to

support the Ghanaian cedi. As we talk now, the Ghanaian cedi has gone back to its usual trend. It is trading at around GH¢12.50. *[Uproar]* Mr Speaker, if they doubt, they should go to the Gold Board website. Mr Speaker, the cedi is facing challenges. They are counting on this particular facility to support the Ghanaian cedi. And if this money comes, we are going to start payment every month in 2031. We will pay about 11 million every month. This debt is for the NPP Government to pay. Because in the next five years, the NPP Government in power will have the burden of paying this facility. They are only taking the facility and the respected Leader of the House knows this. He knows that it is the burden of our Government to pay this debt.

Mr Speaker, I will urge them that they should prioritise the payment of contractors who have not been paid due to the lack of money.

Mr Speaker, with this, I thank you for your attention.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much, Dr Kabiru Mahama.

Yes, let me give the opportunity to the Chairman of the Committee on Economy and Development.

Chairman for the Committee on Economy and Development (Dr Eric Afful): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity. I rise to support the call from the Finance Committee that the honourable House adopt and approve this Report on financing agreement

between the Government of Ghana and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group, of an amount of US\$360 million to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy.

Mr Speaker, my Friends from the other Side, the Minority Side, are behaving as if we are going outside the Appropriation Act, 2025. Mr Speaker, with the Appropriation Act, 2025, we are to finance the Budget with the GH¢56 million after taking the expenditure.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please address me.

7.42 p.m.

Dr Afful: After taking the expenditure from the total revenue, we are to finance this Budget with GH¢56 billion—*[Interruption]*. Go and check the Appropriation Act. *[Uproar]*

Mr Speaker, domestically, we are to finance this with GH¢36.9 billion and externally, it is GH¢21 billion. They should go and check their facts.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Dr Afful, please address me. Do not listen to them.

[Uproar]

Dr Afful: Mr Speaker, what we are saying is that the Government is within the Appropriation Act of financing the Budget, so I do not know what they are complaining about. So, what I want to lay emphasis on is that we need to do

more by adopting this Report so that we can fully finance the Budget.

Second, we all know in this House that within the Budget, we are to finance the capital expenditure of over GH¢32 billion. They can check. Therefore, if we are unable to approve this loan, what will happen? Our roads, water project and others cannot be financed. So, I am urging the House, especially those who are heckling me, to support us to adopt and approve this loan, so that we can run our country and our economy. Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes. Let me now turn to the Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi, Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, the Ranking Member of the Committee on Economy and Development.

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to this Motion currently before the House. There is a background to this transaction, and it is important that we all share it with our Colleagues here and those outside. In 2023, the Government of Ghana, then under the leadership of President Akufo-Addo, negotiated this financing programme. It was for an amount of US\$900 million to support the budget. In March 2024, the first disbursement of US\$300 million of this loan took place. So, ordinarily, we on this Side, now seeing the second disbursement taking place, and hopefully the third, should be fully supportive. But I would like to draw attention to a few

things that are changing, even in the framework that is being brought before this House.

Mr Speaker, first is the subject of candour. It is important for the Government to exercise candour and full transparency with what they are doing. If we notice the communication that has been associated with this facility, be it in the media or even here in the Chamber, on the Order Paper and the Report, there is an attempt to obfuscate. Hon Minister, this is a loan of US\$360 million that this Government is taking. But because they want to hide it, they are deliberately describing it as financing. We understand what financing is. But Mr Speaker, in this Chamber, over and over again, when the Order Paper appears, we talk of a loan agreement—*[Interruption]*. Yes. Why are they running away from the standard expression of a loan? This is a US\$360 million loan agreement which they have brought to Parliament to approve, and that is why I am saying that they must exercise candour.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the Statement or the communication that was issued by the Minister for Finance, following the approval of the World Bank, he also described it as US\$360 million financing. So, if we do not pay attention, we will not realise that the Government is borrowing US\$360 million today, the 1st of July, 2025. It is important that you exercise this candour. They should let the public know that they are taking a loan of US\$360 million, part of the facility that was arranged by the previous administration.

Mr Speaker, the other issue of candour is that when we go into the Report—
[Uproar]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please!

Yes, Mr Oppong Nkrumah?

Mr Nkrumah: I thank you, Mr Speaker. Associated with the issue of candour is the fact that when we now go to the Report of the Committee, we will find that the Committee's Report seeks to change the reason for which this US\$900 million facility, loan, was initially negotiated. I want to refer us to the fourth paragraph. It says:

“The significant deterioration in public finances in 2020 and 2021 led to the 2022 economic crisis, which was characterised...”

Then they go on and try to lay that as the foundation for which reason they are taking this thing that they call financing. When the loan was contracted or when the initial discussions took place, Leader of Government Business, this was not the reason. Let us have candour. This was not the reason. It was because, yes, the Ghanaian economy—[Uproar]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, those who are standing, please!

[Uproar]

Hon Member, let us hear you.

Mr Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, still on the matter of candour, when the original US\$900 million facility was negotiated, it was negotiated as complementary funding coming from the World Bank to complement what the IMF was doing as part of that programme. It was not because of these reasons, but there is obviously an attempt to obfuscate and change the reason, and that is why I am saying that they must have candour. But this is not the first time the Government Side is trying to obfuscate. We recall when they came to this Chamber with the eight per cent levy on fuel. To hide it, they told Ghanaians that it was GHC1 per litre, because they did not want to say that it was eight per cent. This is because they knew that if they had stated the percentage, everybody's attention would go to the fact that it is a high percentage. So, the Chairman and Members of the Committee should please exercise candour when they are bringing these documents to Parliament.

Mr Speaker, the second thing I want to speak about is the utilisation of funds or the use of proceeds. I have in my hands, the Parliamentary Memorandum by Thomas Nyarko Ampem, MP and Deputy Minister for Finance, on the proposed US\$360 million facility. I would invite the House to look at page 11 of 24. Here, they talk about use of proceeds. Chairman of the Committee, if I have your attention. He says:

“Cabinet will recall that in the 2025 Budget, we programmed to spend GHC13 billion owed to

contractors. The full amount of the US\$360 million from the DPO 2 will be used to finance part of this GH¢13 billion. The Ministry of Finance has begun discussion with the World Bank for the third tranche.”

Mr Speaker, they told Cabinet that the full amount of the US\$360 million from the DPO 2 will be used to finance part of this GH¢13 billion payment to contractors. It was not going to be used for goods and services.

Now, let me show them their own Report that they have brought to this Chamber. I will take them to page 8 of this Report. Now that they got Cabinet approval and came to Parliament, they are now saying that they are going to use the money to improve private investment and foreign direct investment, to minimise fiscal burden caused by losses in the power sector. Mr Speaker, we will recall that when they introduced the eight per cent levy on fuel, they told us that they needed money for power sector issues. When they came to Parliament, asking us to amend the Energy Sector Levies Act, before Parliament rose the last time, they told us it was because of power issues.

7.52 p.m.

They went to Cabinet and told Cabinet that they are going to use this money 100 per cent to pay contractors.

Now you are telling us that they would use it for power sector issues. They have gone further to tell us that they are looking to deal with the financial health of the power sector. They are looking to deal with operational and commercial efficiency and they said that they would deal with the protection of the vulnerable and to reduce extreme poverty.

Mr Speaker, now, in Parliament, they are saying that they would improve social safety nets and gender equality. In fact, they go further to say that they would use this money for climate resilience. All of this is on page 8 of their Report.

When they went to Cabinet, they told Cabinet that they would use this money, essentially, to pay contractors. Yes, we understand that there are contractors in the energy sector and various sectors, but if they now come to add to it issues of social safety nets, gender equity, extreme poverty reduction, they are deviating from the original purpose for which this US\$900 million facility was negotiated. Mr Speaker, by the way, if they are going to pay contractors, the contractors on the Akim Oda to Ofoase Road are waiting for their payment —*[Interruption]*— Dr Gideon Boako was telling us a few minutes ago that the contractors from the Bomaa to Tepa Road are waiting for their payment —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, order!

Mr Nkrumah: Mr Speaker, they should not divert —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, it is better we keep quiet, so that we can listen to each other. If you heckle him, someone else will heckle you when you speak. Please, let us help each other so that we finish this exercise on time.

Yes, Hon?

Mr Nkrumah: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

As I was saying, if they are paying contractors, the contractor of the Akim Oda to Ofoase Road is waiting for his payment and the contractor from Bomaa to Tepa is waiting for his payment.

Mr Speaker, in essence, what is happening is that this loan would add US\$360 million to the debt stock and this US\$360 million excludes the interest. A few months ago, when the NPP came to this Chamber requesting for US\$300 million, which obviously would add to the debt stock, our Friends said US\$300 million addition to the debt stock was bad. Today, US\$360 million added to the debt stock is good because they are in power, so they should continue.

Mr Speaker, we want to conclude by drawing the attention of our Colleagues on the other Side to the reasons for which this US\$900 million facility was contracted and urge them to stick to those reasons and not use it for Goods and Services expenditure purposes.

Mr Speaker, I thank you very much for the opportunity. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is there nobody from this Side? I have identified — Very well.

Yes, Hon Member for Effia? But before you begin, give me two minutes to suspend the House.

7.58 p.m. — *Sitting Suspended*

8.00 p.m. — *Sitting Resumed*

[MR SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER
IN THE CHAIR]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, thank you for your indulgence.

Yes, Hon Member for Effia?

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on this Paper that is being presented to this House.

Mr Speaker, let me start by associating myself with a lot of the comments already espoused by Colleagues: Dr Mahama and Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah. Suffice to add that, Mr Speaker, when Government went into this loan contraction, Government agreed to perform some conditions. So when one goes into the Agreement, there are conditions precedent to the releases of these funds. We have indicated some of the conditions that have not been met and actually, at the Committee level, Government accepted the fact that some of the conditions have not been met.

The issue is that if Government does not meet those conditions, it cannot draw down on these resources. What are they? One of them is amending the Ghana Investment Promotion Centre (GIPC) Act.

Mr Speaker, this GIPC Act had come before this House in the last Parliament and efforts were made to lay it in this House, but it could not pass the test of time. Now, six months down the line, Government knowing that this is also a condition precedent to the drawing of this particular facility, what has stopped it from presenting to this House the amendment of the GIPC law in conformity with this particular agreement? It baffles my mind that Government, in contracting this with the International Monetary Fund (IMF), knows that there are certain conditions that has to be fulfilled and those conditions are our part of the bargain, which the previous Parliament had taken steps to that effect, yet, as we speak, they have come to this House to draw this facility or ask us to approve, yet the condition precedent subject to them have all not been met. So, the question is, when would Government ensure that these conditions precedents are made?

Mr Speaker, the second issue that I want to outline is the issue of the amount involved. Yes, we have mentioned that the first time; an amount of US\$900 million was originally meant to be contracted. Now it has ballooned to

US\$1.060 billion. In fact, there is a correction if you go to the document.

8.02 p.m.

If we go to the Report that was submitted to this House, at page 7, if we read the last but one paragraph, it says:

“... the facility was renegotiated and DPO2 was reviewed upward from US\$300 million to US\$360 and then DPO3 also to be reviewed from US\$300 million to US\$400 million, bringing the total to US\$1.6 billion...”

It is not US\$1.6 billion. For the purposes of records in this House, it is US\$1.060 billion. The question is, what actually informed the Government to revise this particular facility? Because at the end of the day, it is adding to our debt stock and we cannot deny that fact.

The Government has told us over time that they want to manage the debts of this country. They said they are not going to borrow to increase the debt stock, so what has changed? Why are we increasing the debts of the people of Ghana? At the end of the day, it is the debt stock of this country that we are piling and generations would have to come back and pay for these loans.

So, Mr Speaker, when we contracted US\$900 million, they have seen the need to increase it to US\$1.06 billion. The additional US\$160 million would also add to the debt. If they could not approve US\$900 million, US\$300 million was to

be drawn down and now, they are increasing it. They would have to explain to the good people of Ghana why they want to increase it.

Now, Mr Speaker, finally, let me draw the attention of Government to why we have to be careful about these facilities. Why? The Government has told us that they are going to improve revenue collection in this country. In fact, we have the privilege of having the Deputy Majority Leader being the Chairman of the Ghana Revenue Authority Board. Where is the revenue increase? If the Government is increasing revenue, then there will be no need to go and borrow this much from the IMF and other quarters. The Government should come up with pragmatic measures to improve revenue collection, so that when we generate the revenue by ourselves, we will be able to expend and reduce the debt stock of this country.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, this particular facility has in itself inherent defects in the area as I have outlined, in terms of our inability to deal with the conditionalities, our inability to pay for the debt that is being ballooned by the Government and finally, steps the Government is taking to improve revenue collection.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to comment on this.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, let me come to the Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute to this Motion and in contributing to this Motion, permit me to refer to the very Report, the subject matter of this debate. Mr Speaker, in particular paragraph 6.3 at page 8, it reads:

“Importance of the Facility

The Committee noted that the US\$360 million facility is not dedicated to any specific project in the 2025 Budget. The Deputy Minister for Finance explained that the facility is part of General Budget Support and will be applied to finance critical aspects of the 2025 Budget. The Committee further noted that the facility constitutes IDAs budget support commitments to Ghana for the period 2023 to 2025.”

Mr Speaker, the issue is, why will the Government bring a facility to Parliament which is not for a specific project as contained in the Budget? How sure are we about how these funds are to be used? The Report that was signed by the Chair of the Committee, Hon Isaac Adongo, says that the Committee requested for the purpose, but the Ministry could not provide. The Committee could not ascertain a specific project in the Budget for which this money is to be applied. I would quote again,

“The Committee noted that the US\$360 million facility is not

dedicated to any specific project in the 2025 Budget.”

This is not me speaking. This is the Report of the Committee and I have circled—It is at page 8. It is a 9-page Report. If they do not behave themselves, they do not have the numbers, so they better keep quiet. Well, they either behave themselves or misbehave at their own peril.

Mr Speaker, paragraph 6.3, at page 8 of the Report, it is written:

“Importance of the facility

The Committee noted that the US\$360 million facility is not dedicated to any specific project in the 2025 Budget.”

This facility, according to the Report of the Committee, signed by the Chairman, tells the people of Ghana that it is not dedicated to any specific project in the 2025 Budget. Yet, they are inviting this House by a Motion to proceed to approve and because their majority is suspicious, they are relying on the benevolence of the Minority to have this passed. They are appealing to our conscience.

Mr Speaker, our Friends in opposition said they were not going to take loans. They said they would not borrow. We had two IDA facilities. The first one that we approved in the Eighth Parliament, that is the US\$250 million which was part of the US\$900 million, I was the Leader of Government Business, I pleaded continuously, but they said they would not even allow us to lay it.

[*Osahen Afenyo-Markin sang*]

8.12 p.m.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Today, all the bridges that—He, the Deputy Minister for Finance, was part of the Finance Committee. Have they seen what they call posterity or karma? See the way Ampem is *mmɔbo* today—[*Laughter*]*—*Now, he is wearing a mask. Does he remember how I begged him? I would call and plead with him. The then Minority Chief Whip would say that if we laid it, there will be chaos in the House. Those were his words: there will be chaos in the House. *Hansard* recorded him and, today, they are in Government and are introducing this same facility that they criticised.

They bastardised the Akufo-Addo Government, where is their principle? Where is their consistency? They told the people of Ghana that it was bad to procure the same loan and they promised that they were going to repeal some taxes at the port. Today, the spare parts dealers are wondering because they promised them.

Mr Speaker, even Ministerial releases — MMDAs have not received their releases. I have some Ministers in this Chamber; I dare them to speak for *Hansard* to record whether they have received their releases. If they have, they should challenge me and say that I am misrepresenting the facts. They should

rise on a point of order; their integrity will be at stake.

Mr Speaker, when one is in opposition and talks, — *[Interruptions]*— they better be calm; they better behave themselves. They do not have the numbers; they better behave themselves. All the empty seats, they better behave themselves. If they want to specialise — especially the Hon Member for Dome Kwabenya, she wants to heckle her Leader. That is what she will do. Today, I will yield for her to speak.

Mr Speaker, our Friends opposite are coming to this House today that we should approve US\$360 million and they come under Order 104 that we should do it today. But we are patriotic; we will not — no, listen. We will not be a Minority that will be coming in to, as it were, act partisan. So far, our conduct in this Chamber — we have raised issues and held them accountable. This is a responsible opposition. We are telling them that US\$250 million, they rejected, where they threatened — we have had a past where even when Papers are being laid, they will physically say no, they will not agree. But Hon Majority Leader, do not forget this day. This is an important equity and as the Majority Leader sleeps, he should dream of ECOWAS and Pan-Africa. Leader of Government Business, Member of Parliament for Bawku Central, a respected member of the Bar, Harvard trained *et cetera*, this day, this equity from the Minority, as the Majority do not have their numbers, please dream of ECOWAS and Pan-Africa. I know that when I talk to my Colleague and Leader

in a language that he understands, he will give meaning to that language. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, today, it is clear that this Government is not living up to its own *bona fides* as it promised the people of Ghana. Where is the 24-Hour Economy? They claim they are launching; the 24-Hour Economy did not find expression in the 2025 Budget. The President promised in the Message on the State of the Nation; he could not deliver it in the Message on the State of the Nation. He then told this House that the Minister for Finance will bring it in his Budget Statement. When the Minister for Finance came to this House, he again said, the 24-Hour Economy is being worked on. So, what it means is that for 2025, it is zero. Where is the one job, three shifts? They said they are taking away 1D1F. What is the alternative policy for the private sector?

What we are rather seeing in the name of accountability is political persecution. Today, instead of seeing an improved economy, we have Ato Forson's rate and we have Alhaji's rate; which one should we take? Even now, we have the Sammy Gyamfi rate. If we go to the Gold Board, Colleagues, this is a serious matter. The Bank of Ghana (BoG) — please, this is not the usual politics. Let us get serious here and let us be consistent. The BoG has its rate. Which rate are we getting to the gallery with and claiming that they have helped the economy? I will be happy because I am a private sector man, if the dollar is stable, it helps the

economy. It helps private sector and we all benefit. We are able to employ more.

Mr Speaker, but we have the Gold Board advertising a different rate from the BoG. We go to the forex bureaus and they also have a different rate.

Mr Speaker, let us, — once again, they should be well-behaved. It may affect them. Once again, they should be reminded of the empty seats. It will affect them. So, they should humble themselves and take these criticisms. — I am not concluding now because their Side decided not to speak and I am — yes, no problem, let us make our point. That is governance; of course, it is relevant. Why would they have an exchange rate at BoG, different rate at Gold Board and a different rate at the forex bureaus? What kind of economy are they running? They are not paying contractors; nurses are calling for salary increment but they say they do not have it.

Mr Speaker, our Friends came into office with promises and high expectations. The youth are expecting that this Women's Development Bank will be actualised. They only allocated a paltry sum of GH¢50 million. How do we use GH¢50 million to set up Women's Development Bank? GH¢50 million? A so-called seed fund? Which seed? Where are they sowing the seed? Mr Backbencher, sit down. This is a serious debate. How many women are going to benefit from this? They said they are setting up Women's

Development Bank in all areas of the country.

Mr Speaker, where is it? In the educational sector, they told us that they are going to ensure that the headteachers will do their own procurement. So they are also interested in centralised procurement. So all they did was to win power? Today, they have come to this House to tell us that they want a US\$360 million —

8.22 p.m.

Today, they have come to this House to tell us they want a US\$360 million— After all, they also want IMF support; After all, they want the World Bank support. And like Hon Oppong Nkrumah said, we have some Members who stood and criticised the NPP and said, “no”. Where are their views? Their silence is too loud. What is their attitude towards women? Are they giving them equal opportunity? They have many women on their Side; 40 of the women— *[Interruption]*—Hajia Laadi Ayamba, have not been given an appointment. Hon Helen Ntoso, no appointment? The Member for Dome Kwabenya, no appointment? Mr Speaker, what is this government really up to? Mr Speaker, today, when the power has been given to them, the true colours of this Government is now known. Power has exposed them. Power has exposed their

weakness. Theirs is campaign talk, not governance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, I need to speak my heart out. Mr Speaker, in the Report, they are talking about using some of the money for improved social safety net and gender equality. They also said to improve protection for vulnerable and reduce extreme poverty. That is where I want to land.

Mr Speaker, I am concerned about the vulnerable women and youth in our Zongo communities. I am concerned—The Zongo communities, the poor farmers, Mr Speaker, I expect them to walk the talk because they themselves have spoken about this. I want them to dedicate some of these funds to some of these communities where our women need the support.

Mr Speaker, not too long ago, Hon Hajia Laadi spoke about the suffering of some of the women in her constituency. I want some of this support to go there. Water is a problem; They have to walk long distances for water. These poor women in our Zongo communities, need small support. So, if indeed they said they would use it to protect vulnerable people and reduce extreme poverty, then they should really be committed.

[Interruption]

Mr Speaker, my community needs support. There are people who are

vulnerable in my own community and they need to be supported. I do not think that merely talking about it is enough. The Government must be committed to indeed supporting vulnerable groups.

Mr Speaker—*[Pause]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, are you done?

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, they are making noise.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Kindly conclude.

Hon Members, please be silent for the Leader to conclude.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, what they have forgotten is that after me, their Leader will also speak. So at least they should relax and be calm.

Mr Speaker, I shall conclude by urging the Government to approach governance with the utmost sincerity. We saw them at display when they were in opposition and we are seeing them again now that they are in government. We say to the Government that upon approval of this facility, they should endeavour to bring before Parliament how these funds were spent. It is part of their accountability. That the Deputy Minister who is standing in for the Minister should commit to it for our record that they will bring to Parliament how they spent this money.

Mr Speaker, that said, I shall rest my case. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Deputy Minister, you may conclude for us.

Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the Minority Leader has just contributed to the approval process and he spoke about the dollar rate and the 24-Hour Economy. In his concluding remarks, he also spoke about the Women's Development Bank; He spoke about the true colours of the Government and he spoke about water problems. At a point, I was wondering what we were doing here. But, Mr Speaker, we are here to seek approval of this honourable House for us to access an amount of US\$360 million to support the 2025 Budget.

Mr Speaker, this is the simple task that this House is being called upon to perform. I have heard many speakers on this particular topic and every one of them, including the Minority Leader, stated clearly that the terms of this facility are very favourable and that is the important part of the conversation that I want us to dwell on.

Mr Speaker, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah was suggesting that using the word 'financing' is misleading and that we are not being candid to Ghanaians. And I am so surprised that this is coming from my good Friend and Brother who really understands the meaning of

'financing'. It is so surprising that he tries to create this misleading impression.

Mr Speaker, the point has been made by many earlier speakers that this facility was actually negotiated by the previous administration and that they even accessed the first US\$300 million in March, 2024. It is the second tranche that we are financing. Mr Speaker, if you look at the Budget that this House approved, under Financing, if you look at the total amount to be financed from foreign sources of which World Bank DPO, an amount of US\$9.79 billion was allocated there and this House approved it. It is that facility that today we are calling on them to approve a part of; that is US\$360 million for us to finance the Budget.

8.32 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Hon Minority Leader and his Colleagues have suggested that by using this amount for Budget support, we are not using it for any specific project. In fact, at the Committee level, I stated clearly, the intentions and the use for this facility, that we are going to use it to pay arrears.

We would recall that when Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson was presenting the Budget, he stated that we inherited arrears stock of about GHC67 billion. We programmed to pay GHC13 billion in this year's Budget. The decision of President Mahama's Government is that this US\$360 million is going to be used to pay part of the arrears, the GHC13

billion that we have programmed to pay this year. We are hoping that we will access another US\$400 million by October/November this year. That also will be committed to pay the arrears that we inherited from the Minority.

So, the good news today is that contractors are going to be paid. [*Hear! Hear!*] Mr Speaker, the Auditor-General has just concluded the audit of the arrears stock that we inherited. The amounts that are cleared are going to be paid for, starting from the utilisation of this facility. So, this facility and the one we will access in October/November will come to a total of about GHC8 billion. All of that will be used, and the remaining will be financed from domestic sources.

So, Mr Speaker, if our Hon Friends are asking — In fact, I am happy that even though they say all sorts of things, their concluding remarks point to the fact that they are in support of this facility. Dr Mahama was quoting some exchange rates. In fact, the official rate is GHC10.3 to US\$1. They told us that *sika mpe dede*, so, they should stop the *dede* about the *sika*. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, I want to thank all Hon Members for supporting this facility. The Minority Leader is asking us to come back and show. In fact, even though we are saying that this is not tied up to any particular project, because we are going to use it to pay contractors, it is going to be used to pay for projects; multiple projects. So, this GHC360 billion is going to be used to finance many projects. What we did not want to do was to tell the House that it is going to be used to finance Ofoase Ayirebi road or to

finance a particular road. We are going to use it to pay arrears that are linked to specific projects. At the end of the day, we will see many projects that have been financed from this facility.

So, Mr Speaker, I want to urge all of us to support the approval of this and we will be back to let the House know that the amount has been put to better use. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, kindly take the Resolution for us; the item numbered 4.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, the Minister is in a hurry to leave this Chamber.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister, Resolution, the item numbered 4 on the Order Paper *Addendum*.

RESOLUTION

Financing Agreement between the GoG and IDA of the World Bank Group for the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing

Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) on behalf of the Minister: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

WHEREAS

1. By the provisions of Article 181 of the Constitution and sections

55 and 56 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), the terms and conditions of all Government borrowing shall be laid before Parliament and shall not come into operation unless the terms and conditions are approved by a resolution of Parliament in accordance with Article 181 of the Constitution.

2. Pursuant to the provisions of the said Article 181 of the Constitution and sections 55 and 56 of the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921), at the request of the Government of the Republic of Ghana acting through the Minister responsible for Finance, there has been laid before Parliament a Financing Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and the International Development Association (IDA) of the World Bank Group for an amount of Three Hundred and Sixty Million United States Dollars (US\$360,000,000.00) to finance the Second Resilient Recovery Development Policy Financing.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, who is seconding the Motion.

Chairman of the Committee (Mr Isaac Adongo): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Leader?

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, let me thank Colleagues for the support that we have received to pass this Financing Agreement. Clearly, in the not-too-distant future, contractors will be smiling to their banks.

Mr Speaker, I am surprised that the Hon Minority Leader would even be delaying this Financing Agreement by an hour, because he has been advocating for contractors to be smiling to their banks. And when we are laying a facility that will enable that, then he is delaying the process. But I thank him very much for his support and I have not forgotten about ECOWAS Parliament, and I will not forget about Pan-African Parliament and the parables that he spoke this evening.

Mr Speaker, just to announce before you give us the indications, that the Prime Minister of India will be visiting Ghana on a State visit. When he comes, he will visit and address us in Parliament. That will be on Thursday at exactly 10 a.m. The programme has allotted only 30 minutes to Parliament House, so we will convene at 9:00 a.m. and start the Business of the day, make sure we are all here in our numbers, prepare the place, so that he will arrive exactly at 10:00

a.m. He will address the House as he has to leave here exactly at 10.30 a.m.

8.42 p.m.

So, I am pleading with Colleagues to make it a point to be here on Thursday at 9.00 a.m. and we will receive the Prime Minister at exactly 10 a.m.

Mr Speaker, I do not think I have any other announcement except to thank Colleagues for what has happened this evening.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, at this juncture, I think I will not be far from right to say you are in my hands now.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, that is true; we are in your hands and the Majority Leader thanked the House for the loan that was eventually approved. We pray that the loan agreement that has been approved will be put to good use for the benefit of the people of Ghana.

Mr Speaker that has been said already. The contractor has left the site of the Kasoa - Winneba Road and it is making motorists suffer. The Oda - Ofoase—Mr Speaker, your constituency—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, my constituency—

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: The contractors have abandoned the sites of the Fomena roads.

Mr Speaker, I would just plead with you to let them know that these contractors are doing major roads that need support.

Mr Speaker that is all for now.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, we have spent a lot of time. Let me thank you for your cooperation. It is now beyond 8 o'clock, so we would adjourn the House to tomorrow at 12 noon; not 2 o'clock.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 8.47 p.m. till Wednesday, 2nd July, 2025, at 12.00 noon.

